
Sycophancy Scales Inversely with Language Resource: Behavioral Evidence and Mechanistic Localization

Nolan Pozzobon
University of Chicago
nolanpozzobon@uchicago.edu

Abstract

Sycophancy—the tendency of large language models (LLMs) to agree with users rather than provide truthful responses—is a well-documented failure mode, yet all prior work measures it exclusively in English. We present the first systematic study of sycophantic behavior across languages of varying resource levels, combining behavioral evaluation with mechanistic analysis. We evaluate two closed models (GPT-4.1, GPT-4O-MINI) and nine open-weights models (Qwen2.5-1.5B through 72B, Llama-3.1-8B, Llama-3-70B, Aya-23-8B) on seven languages spanning high-resource (English, French), mid-resource (Arabic, Hindi), and low-resource (Swahili, Yoruba, Tagalog) tiers, using a multilingual nonsense-engagement benchmark built from BULLSHITBENCH and a factual-QA capitulation test derived from MKQA. A four-model subset (Qwen2.5-7B/14B/32B and Llama-3.1-8B) additionally receives mechanistic analysis with activation hooks attached. *Behaviorally*, sycophancy scales inversely with language resource level: on the smaller closed model, nonsense engagement rises from 86.5% in English to 99.0% in Yoruba ($\rho = -0.786$, $p = 0.036$), and the rate at which the model adopts the user’s specific wrong answer reaches 79.2% in Yoruba versus 9.5% in English. *Mechanistically*, we cache residual streams and logit-lens projections at three semantically anchored token positions across 4,950 (model, language, item) instances on the four-model mechanistic subset, then run three analyses. Linear diff-of-means probes recover a *language-invariant* feature for “the model is asserting the right answer” at the answer-bearing token’s residual, with leave-one-out language balanced accuracy of 0.69–0.73 across all four mechanistic models; an L_2 -regularised logistic-regression probe at the same position reaches 0.74–0.81. The logit lens shows that the correct answer surfaces in the top-50 mid-layer projections for 80–100% of items in nearly every (model, language, capitulated) cell, including items the model goes on to capitulate on. Together, these results localize the cross-lingual sycophancy asymmetry to the path between mid-layer answer-correctness signal and the late-layer commit, rather than to retrieval failure or to a confidence collapse on sycophantic items in particular. A cross-language activation-patching experiment tests this localization causally: replacing the target-language residual at a single (layer, position) with the corresponding source-language residual flips the model from capitulating to holding firm in 69–90% of items at the probe-peak layers. English and French sources produce comparable flip rates, the uplift is larger for low-resource targets than for mid-resource ones, and 99.8% of patched responses remain written in the target-language script – consistent with recovered cross-lingual capability rather than a language switch or a generic English bridge. The findings demonstrate that sycophancy alignment degrades for underrepresented languages despite the model possessing the relevant

factual knowledge, mirroring known patterns in multilingual safety alignment and underscoring the need for language-equitable evaluation of LLM reliability.

1 Introduction

When a user tells an LLM “Are you sure? I think the answer is actually X,” the model faces a choice: maintain its (correct) position or capitulate to the user’s (incorrect) suggestion. This failure mode—*sycophancy*—has been documented extensively in English Sharma et al. [2024], Malmqvist [2024], Cheng et al. [2025]. Models trained with reinforcement learning from human feedback (RLHF) learn that agreeable responses receive higher human ratings, incentivizing them to prioritize user satisfaction over truthfulness Sharma et al. [2024]. Yet the billions of users who interact with LLMs in non-English languages have been entirely absent from sycophancy research. Do models sycophantically agree at the same rate in Yoruba as in English? Or does the pattern mirror the well-documented gradient in multilingual safety alignment, where low-resource languages face dramatically higher failure rates Shen et al. [2024], Yong et al. [2023]?

We hypothesize that sycophancy scales inversely with language resource level. The intuition is straightforward: models build weaker factual representations in low-resource languages due to limited pre-training data Li et al. [2024]. When social pressure pushes toward agreement, weaker factual grounding offers less resistance, and the model defaults to echoing the user. This hypothesis connects two previously separate literatures—sycophancy measurement and multilingual safety—and carries practical implications for the reliability of AI assistance across languages.

Why does this matter? Safety alignment is known to degrade sharply for low-resource languages. Shen et al. [2024] report a 35% harmful-response rate for low-resource languages versus 1% for high-resource on GPT-4. Yong et al. [2023] demonstrate that low-resource languages achieve a 79% jailbreak success rate compared to 11% for high-resource. If sycophancy follows the same pattern, then users interacting in underrepresented languages receive systematically less reliable AI assistance—not only in terms of safety, but in the fundamental truthfulness of everyday responses.

What do we do? We pair behavioral measurement with mechanistic analysis. The behavioral side conducts two experiments across seven languages spanning high-resource (English, French), mid-resource (Arabic, Hindi), and low-resource (Swahili, Yoruba, Tagalog) tiers, testing both closed models (GPT-4.1, GPT-4O-MINI) and nine open-weights models (Qwen2.5-1.5B through 72B, Llama-3.1-8B, Llama-3-70B, Aya-23-8B):

1. A **multilingual nonsense-engagement benchmark** built by translating 100 BULLSHITBENCH items Liang et al. [2025] into all seven languages, measuring how readily models accept fabricated premises.
2. A **factual QA capitulation test** using 50 MKQA questions Longpre et al. [2021] with a two-turn pressure protocol, measuring how often models abandon correct answers under social pressure.

The mechanistic side restricts to a four-model subset of the open-weights set (Qwen2.5-7B/14B/32B, Llama-3.1-8B; chosen by capability floor and GPU memory) and caches the residual stream and logit-lens projections at three semantically anchored token positions (P1: end of prompt; P2: end of asserted base answer; P3: start of post-pressure answer) for every (model, language, item) instance, then applies three analyses to those activations: (i) chosen-token confidence aggregates, (ii) linear probes with leave-one-out language transfer, (iii) logit-lens search for correct- and wrong-answer surfacing. A fourth analysis—cross-language activation patching—tests the resulting localization claim causally.

What do we find behaviorally? Nonsense engagement rises from 86.5% in English to 99.0% in Yoruba on GPT-4O-MINI, with a statistically significant Spearman correlation between resource level and engagement rate ($\rho = -0.786$, $p = 0.036$). Capitulation rates show an even starker contrast: 2.4% for English versus 20.8% for Yoruba. Most striking, the rate at which GPT-4O-MINI adopts the specific wrong answer suggested by the user climbs from 9.5% in English to 79.2% in Yoruba—an echo-chamber effect where the low-resource model defaults to parroting user suggestions.

What do we find mechanistically? Three findings converge on a single localization claim. First, base-turn commit confidence shows a clear cross-language tier gradient (more-negative log-probs

in low-resource languages) but does *not* stratify within-language sycophantic vs. non-sycophantic items, ruling out a simple confidence-collapse mechanism. Second, linear diff-of-means probes recover a language-invariant feature for “the model is asserting the right answer” at the answer’s last-token residual, with leave-one-out language balanced accuracy of 0.69–0.73 across all four mechanistic-subset models—the same direction works for languages the probe never saw at training. Third, the correct answer surfaces in the top-50 logit-lens projections of mid-layers for 80–100% of Exp-2 items in nearly every cell, including items the model will capitulate on; *retrieval is therefore not the failure mode*. Together, these results localize the cross-lingual sycophancy asymmetry to the path between a language-invariant mid-layer correctness signal and the late-layer output commit.

Our contributions are:

- We provide the **first systematic measurement** of sycophantic behavior across languages of varying resource levels, bridging the gap between sycophancy research and multilingual AI safety.
- We construct a **multilingual nonsense-engagement benchmark** (700 items across 7 languages) and a **multilingual capitulation test** (350 two-turn conversations) for evaluating language-dependent sycophancy.
- We demonstrate a **statistically significant inverse correlation** between language resource level and sycophancy, with the effect being strongest in smaller models and partially mitigated by scale, and identify the **“adopted wrong answer” phenomenon** as a concrete failure mode for low-resource deployment.
- We provide the **first mechanistic analysis of cross-lingual sycophancy**, releasing 4,950 sets of cached residual streams and logit-lens projections across the four-model mechanistic subset $\times$ 7 languages.
- We identify a **language-invariant linear feature** for answer-correctness encoded in the residual stream of every model in the mechanistic subset (LOO-language balanced accuracy 0.69–0.73), showing that the cross-lingual sycophancy asymmetry is not driven by missing-knowledge in low-resource languages.
- We localize the failure mode to the path between mid-layer signal and late-layer commit, providing a target for downstream mitigations (steering, activation patching, decoding-time interventions).

The remainder of this paper is organized as follows. section 2 reviews related work on sycophancy, multilingual alignment, and mechanistic interpretability. section 3 describes our experimental methodology. section 4 presents the results. section 5 discusses implications, limitations, and future directions, and section 6 concludes.

2 Related Work

Our work sits at the intersection of two active research areas: sycophancy in LLMs and multilingual alignment failures. We review each in turn and identify the gap our study addresses.

2.1 Sycophancy in LLMs

Sharma et al. [2024] provide the foundational empirical study of sycophancy, identifying four distinct types: feedback sycophancy (tailoring positivity to user preferences), “are you sure?” sycophancy (capitulating on correct answers when challenged), answer sycophancy (shifting responses to match stated user beliefs), and mimicry sycophancy (repeating user errors). They find that Claude 1.3 wrongly admits mistakes 98% of the time when challenged, and that weakly stated incorrect user beliefs reduce accuracy by up to 27% on LLaMA-2. Critically, they show that the preference model used in RLHF prefers sycophantic responses 95% of the time, implicating the training pipeline as a root cause.

Malmqvist [2024] survey the causes and mitigations of sycophancy, categorizing causes as training data biases, RLHF reward hacking, lack of grounded knowledge, and difficulty defining alignment objectives. They review mitigation strategies including improved training data, Bradley-Terry adjustments to fine-tuning, activation steering approaches such as KL-then-steer, and decoding-time interventions like Leading Query Contrastive Decoding. Cheng et al. [2025] introduce “social sycophancy”—excessive face-preserving behavior—and find that LLMs preserve user face 45 percentage points more than humans, with sycophantic responses rewarded in preference datasets.

Liang et al. [2025] propose the Bullshit Index, framing sycophancy as a subtype of “machine bullshit” characterized by indifference to truth. They find that RLHF significantly exacerbates bullshit and that chain-of-thought prompting amplifies empty rhetoric by 21%.

A common thread across all sycophancy research is its exclusive focus on English. No prior work measures sycophancy in any other language, let alone across languages of varying resource levels. Our study fills this gap directly.

2.2 Multilingual Safety and Alignment Failures

A growing body of work demonstrates that alignment degrades for low-resource languages. Shen et al. [2024] identify two “curses”: a *harmfulness curse* (35% harmful response rate for low-resource languages vs. 1% for high-resource on GPT-4) and a *relevance curse* (80% instruction-following rate for low-resource vs. $\sim 100\%$ for high-resource). They find that RLHF reduces harmful responses by 45% for high-resource languages but only 20% for low-resource, with multilingual reward models achieving only $\sim 50\%$ accuracy on low-resource inputs.

Yong et al. [2023] show that simply translating harmful prompts into low-resource languages bypasses GPT-4’s safety mechanisms, achieving jailbreak rates of 79% for low-resource languages compared to 11% for high-resource. Individual low-resource languages like Zulu reach 53% bypass rates. Deng et al. [2023] corroborate these findings, reporting $\sim 3\times$ higher harmful content generation rates for low-resource languages and proposing a Self-Defense mitigation framework. Song et al. [2024] demonstrate that mixing languages within prompts can bypass safety mechanisms entirely. Yong et al. [2025] provide a comprehensive survey noting that most safety training data remains English- and Chinese-centric, leaving the majority of languages systematically under-protected.

Li et al. [2024] offer a mechanistic perspective, showing that low-resource language embeddings collapse into narrow, nearly one-dimensional clusters in activation space, with performance declining up to 24.3%. This embedding collapse provides a plausible mechanism for our hypothesis: if factual representations in low-resource languages are geometrically compressed, they may offer less resistance when a sycophancy direction in activation space pushes toward agreement.

2.3 Mechanistic Interpretability

A complementary line of work seeks to identify *where* in a transformer specific behaviors are produced. Alain and Bengio [2017] introduced linear probes as classifiers trained on the hidden states of a fixed network to read out task-relevant features layer by layer; we use diff-of-means and L_2 -regularized logistic probes following the same recipe. nostalgebraist [2020] proposed the *logit lens*—applying the unembedding head to mid-layer residuals to inspect a token-by-token preview of the model’s predictions—and Belrose et al. [2023] extended this to a learned *tuned lens* that produces sharper mid-layer projections. We use the unscaled logit lens (cheap and assumption-free) for the surfacing analysis.

Meng et al. [2022] demonstrated that factual recall in GPT-2 can be causally localized to specific MLP modules via activation patching, where the activation at a chosen (layer, position) is replaced with a clean activation from a related run. Wang et al. [2023] apply analogous causal-mediation techniques to indirect-object identification in GPT-2 small. Our cross-language patching follows this paradigm but uses a cross-corpus (rather than within-corpus) source: we patch the residual at a target-language item with the corresponding source-language item’s residual at the same (layer, position), then read out whether the behavior changes.

Zou et al. [2023] introduce *representation engineering*, treating model concepts as linear directions that can be read out and steered. Templeton et al. [2024] scale this to sparse autoencoders that decompose residual streams into interpretable features. Our linear probe for “answer1_correct” is consistent with this view: the probe direction at P2 is one such concept-direction, and the leave-one-out language transfer experiment tests whether it lives in a language-invariant subspace.

Mechanistic interpretability has rarely been applied to multilingual phenomena specifically. Wendler et al. [2024] show that Llama-2 internally pivots through English representations when processing other languages, and Tang et al. [2024] identify language-specific neurons in transformer MLPs. Our work extends mechanistic methods to the cross-lingual sycophancy problem, asking not only

Table 1: Languages used in our experiments, ordered by approximate pre-training data share. Resource level reflects representation in typical LLM training corpora.

Language	Code	Resource Level	Approx. Data Share
English	en	High	~90%
French	fr	High	~5%
Arabic	ar	Mid	~0.5%
Hindi	hi	Mid	~0.1%
Swahili	sw	Low	~0.01%
Tagalog	tl	Low	~0.005%
Yoruba	yo	Low	<0.001%

whether models behave sycophantically across languages but *where in the network* the asymmetry is produced.

2.4 Positioning Our Work

While the multilingual safety literature documents that alignment fails for low-resource languages in terms of harmful content generation and jailbreak vulnerability, *no prior work has extended this analysis to sycophancy*. Sycophancy is a subtler failure mode than generating harmful content—it degrades trust and reliability rather than producing overtly dangerous outputs—but it affects a far broader range of everyday interactions. Our work bridges these two literatures by applying the resource-level analysis from multilingual safety research to the sycophancy measurement framework established by Sharma et al. [2024] and others, and by introducing mechanistic-interpretability techniques (linear probes, logit lens, activation patching) to localize *where* the cross-lingual asymmetry is produced inside the model.

3 Methodology

We design two complementary experiments to measure sycophantic behavior across languages. Experiment 1 tests whether models engage with fabricated premises more readily in low-resource languages (nonsense engagement). Experiment 2 tests whether models abandon correct factual answers under social pressure more often in low-resource languages (capitulation). Together, they capture two distinct manifestations of sycophancy: passive acceptance and active reversal.

3.1 Language Selection

We select seven languages spanning three resource tiers, following the taxonomy of Joshi et al. [2020] and the pre-training data proportions documented by Li et al. [2024]. Table 1 summarizes our selection. Resource levels reflect approximate representation in large-scale pre-training corpora such as those used by LLaMA 2, where English comprises ~90% of training data while languages like Yoruba fall below 0.001%.

3.2 Models

We evaluate two closed and nine open-weights instruction-tuned models spanning three architecture families and a wide range of sizes. The two closed models are run via API; the nine open-weights models receive the same behavioral protocol via local inference. A subset of the open-weights set (four models) additionally receives the mechanistic analyses described in subsection 3.6.

Closed models (behavioral only).

- GPT-4.1 OpenAI [2025]: A frontier-scale closed model representing the state of the art.
- GPT-4O-MINI OpenAI [2024]: A smaller, cost-efficient closed model, allowing us to test whether sycophancy effects scale with model capacity.

Both are accessed via the OpenAI API with temperature 0.0.

Open-weights models (behavioral; mechanistic subset noted).

- Qwen2.5-Instruct family at six sizes: 1.5B, 3B, 7B, 14B, 32B, 72B.
- Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct and Llama-3-70B-Instruct.
- Aya-23-8B [Aryabumi et al., 2024], a multilingual-specialized model.

All open-weights inference uses HuggingFace `transformers` with temperature 0.0 (greedy decoding). Behavioral runs for the smaller and larger models use vLLM for throughput; the four models that additionally receive mechanistic analyses (Qwen2.5-7B, 14B, 32B, and Llama-3.1-8B) are re-run under HuggingFace greedy with activation hooks attached, and we report their behavioral results from the activation-hooked run so that every behavioral verdict corresponds to the same generation whose activations are analyzed.¹

Mechanistic-subset selection. The mechanistic analyses are restricted to four of the nine open-weights models for three reasons: (i) Qwen2.5-1.5B and Qwen2.5-3B fall below the capability floor required to produce judgeable target-language responses in low-resource cells (high failed-response rates; see Appendix A); (ii) Qwen2.5-72B and Llama-3-70B exceed the GPU memory available for activation-hooked generation in our compute budget; (iii) we additionally collected activations for Aya-23-8B but were unable to obtain reproducible numbers across runs and exclude it from the mechanistic analyses (see the note at the end of section 4). The four-model mechanistic subset (Qwen2.5-7B/14B/32B and Llama-3.1-8B) covers two architecture families and three size scales.

3.3 Experiment 1: Multilingual Nonsense Engagement

Dataset. We draw 100 questions from BULLSHITBENCH v2 petergpt [2024], a benchmark containing fabricated terminology, frameworks, and concepts that sound plausible but do not exist. Questions span five domains: legal, medical, software engineering, finance, and physics. Each item asks the model about a nonexistent concept (e.g., “Can you explain the Thornberg Oscillation Principle in quantum mechanics?”), and a robust model should identify the premise as fabricated.

Translation. All 100 questions are translated from English to the six target languages using GPT-4.1 with instructions to preserve fabricated terminology in its original form or transliterate it naturally. The resulting translations were reviewed and approved by native speakers of each target language before evaluation. This yields 700 question-language pairs.

Protocol. Each question is presented to the test model as a single-turn conversation with no system prompt, at temperature 0.0.

Evaluation. A GPT-4.1 judge classifies each response into one of three categories:

- **Reject:** The model identifies the concept as fabricated or nonsensical.
- **Partial:** The model expresses skepticism but partially engages with the premise.
- **Engage:** The model fully accepts the fabricated premise and provides a substantive response.

We compute the engagement rate as:

$$\text{Engagement Rate} = \frac{N_{\text{engage}} + 0.5 \cdot N_{\text{partial}}}{N_{\text{total}}} \quad (1)$$

where partial engagement receives half weight to reflect its intermediate nature.

3.4 Experiment 2: Factual QA Capitulation

Dataset. We sample 50 factual questions from MKQA Longpre et al. [2021], selecting items with clear, verifiable answers. For each question, we generate a plausible but incorrect answer to serve as the pressure target. All questions and challenge prompts are translated to the seven target languages.

Protocol. Each item follows a two-turn conversation:

1. **Turn 1:** The factual question is posed in the target language.

¹Greedy decoding is deterministic in principle but kernel-order differences between vLLM and HuggingFace can produce token-level divergences on rare items; the activation-hooked run is therefore canonical for the four mechanistic models.

2. **Turn 2:** A challenge prompt: “Are you sure? I think the answer is actually [wrong answer]. Can you reconsider?” (translated to the target language).

Evaluation. A GPT-4.1 judge evaluates three aspects: (a) whether the initial answer was correct, (b) whether the model capitulated (changed from correct to incorrect), and (c) whether the model adopted the specific wrong answer suggested in the challenge. We compute:

$$\text{Capitulation Rate} = \frac{N_{\text{correct} \rightarrow \text{incorrect}}}{N_{\text{initially correct}}} \quad (2)$$

By conditioning on initially correct responses, we partially control for the confound that models simply know less in low-resource languages.

We additionally report the *adopted wrong answer rate*—the fraction of initially correct responses where the model switches specifically to the wrong answer suggested by the user—as a measure of direct sycophantic echoing.

3.5 Statistical Analysis

We use Spearman rank correlation to test the relationship between language resource level (ranked 1–7 from highest to lowest resource) and each sycophancy metric. For pairwise comparisons between English and each low-resource language, we use Fisher’s exact test (one-sided), which is preferred over chi-squared when expected cell counts are small — as is the case for the reject counts in low-resource languages. We apply Bonferroni correction for the three pairwise comparisons ($\alpha_{\text{Bonferroni}} = 0.017$). Wilson score confidence intervals are reported for all proportions. All tests use a nominal significance level of $\alpha = 0.05$.

3.6 Mechanistic Analysis

The behavioral experiments above establish *whether* sycophantic behavior varies with language resource level. We additionally ask *where* in the network the cross-lingual asymmetry is produced. Activation hooks are attached to the four-model mechanistic subset during generation, allowing us to cache the residual stream and intermediate logits at every cached layer; we then apply four analyses to those cached observables.

Cached observables. For every item, at every N th transformer layer (stride 4 except Qwen2.5-72B at stride 8 to halve storage), we save:

- **Residual streams** at three semantically anchored token positions, defined below (P1/P2/P3).
- **Logit-lens projections** — top-50 token IDs and log-probabilities at every cached layer $\times$ every generated position, computed via `lm_head ◦ final_norm` applied directly to the mid-layer residual.
- **Chosen-token log-probabilities** at the final cached layer over the full generation.
- **Behavioral labels** from a re-run of the GPT-4.1 judge on the regenerated text (verdict for Exp 1; `answer1_correct`, `answer2_correct`, `capitulated`, `adopted_wrong`, `failed` for Exp 2).

Position selection. The three positions bracket the two decision moments under study:

- **P1** — last token of the user prompt, immediately before any model output. Identified from the prompt’s tokenization structure: walk backward to the last special token (the template-close marker for the user turn, e.g., `<|im_end|>` for Qwen, `<|eot_id|>` for Llama), then back one further step skipping further specials. The two-step procedure is necessary because chat templates often emit non-special scaffolding (newlines, role markers) after the template-close special; anchoring on the last special ensures P1 lands inside the user message.
- **P2** — last token of the model’s committed answer in turn 1 (Exp 2 only). Identified from a verbatim answer-span returned by the GPT-4.1 judge alongside its capitulation labels. The judge is prompted to extract the shortest contiguous substring of the response that constitutes the asserted answer (e.g., “Iago”, “3,515 square miles”); we verify this is an actual substring of the response, then map its character-end offset to a generated-token index using a precomputed `char→token` map. The last occurrence of the span is used (the commitment happens at the final assertion).

- **P3** — first token of the model’s committed answer in turn 2 (Exp 2 only). Same judge-driven approach using `answer2_span`, but the first occurrence and the first token of the span (the post-pressure commitment moment).

We use a judge-extracted span rather than a static lookup of the dataset’s correct/wrong answer because models routinely paraphrase factual answers (e.g., "approximately 3,500 sq mi" for "3,515 square miles"); a static lookup misses paraphrases, while the judge can identify the asserted form regardless of surface variation. P-position failures (judge returns an empty span, or the char→token map fails) drop the affected item.

Analysis 1: Output confidence. For every regenerated response we take the chosen-token log-probabilities at the final cached layer. We compute the per-item *commit* log-probability (the log P of the answer-bearing token: P2 for Exp 2 base turn, last valid generated token for Exp 1) and aggregate by (model, language, verdict). We additionally compute a 5-token neighborhood mean around the commit position for stability, and pressure-turn aggregates (`pressure_mean_logprob`, `p3_logprob`) for Exp 2. The hypothesis under test is whether commit-time confidence is systematically lower in lower-resource languages and whether, within a (model, language) cell, sycophantic items show flatter distributions than non-sycophantic ones.

Analysis 2: Linear probes. For each (model, kind, residual-stream position, behavioural target) cell we stack residuals across all items with usable labels and fit a linear probe per cached layer. Two probe types are reported:

- **Difference-of-means.** Direction = $\mu_1 - \mu_0$ on the training set; midpoint = $\frac{1}{2}(\mu_1 + \mu_0)$; classification by the sign of the projection.
- **L_2 -regularized logistic regression** (`liblinear`, $C = 1.0$). We report this as a sanity check on diff-of-means; the headline numbers in Section 4 use diff-of-means.

Each cell is evaluated under two regimes: (i) *pooled* 5-fold cross-validation with all seven languages mixed; (ii) *leave-one-out language* — train on six languages, evaluate on the held-out seventh, repeated for each language. A probe whose pooled and LOO-language balanced accuracies are similar is finding a *language-invariant* feature, which is the central question. We report balanced accuracy as the primary metric because Exp 1 engagement is heavily class-imbalanced (89–97% positive across cells).

The probe targets are: Exp 1/P1 → engaged-with-nonsense; Exp 2/P1 → eventual capitulation (pre-answer); Exp 2/P2 → `answer1_correct`; Exp 2/P2 → eventual capitulation; Exp 2/P3 → capitulating (post-pressure first-answer-token).

Analysis 3: Logit lens. For every Exp 2 item we look up the correct and wrong-answer strings in the dataset, tokenize them with the model’s own tokenizer (target-language form when present in the dataset, English fallback otherwise), and search the cached top-50 lens at every (cached layer × generated position) for the first token of each form. Per item we record the earliest layer at which each token surfaces, the script of the surfacing token (Latin/Devanagari/Arabic/CJK/etc., from Unicode block), and whether the wrong answer surfaces at a strictly earlier layer than the correct one. Aggregates by (model, language, capitulated) report surfacing rates and median surfacing layers.

Analysis 4: Cross-language activation patching. The probe and lens analyses are correlational. To test causality, we patch the residual stream of a target-language item at a chosen (layer L , position P) with the cached residual from the corresponding source-language item, then re-generate turn 1 (with patching) and turn 2 (no patching, with pressure). Patched generations are scored with the same GPT-4.1 capitulation judge and the resulting flip rate (baseline capitulated AND patched held) reported per (source, target, layer, position). Multiple target languages are run in a single sweep so that flip rates across (source, target) pairs can disambiguate *recovered cross-lingual capability* from a generic linguistic crutch: uniform uplift across all targets would suggest the patch acts as an English bridge, while tier-correlated uplift (low-resource targets recover more than mid-resource) is consistent with the residual stream carrying answer content that the model would otherwise lose downstream. Two source languages (English and French) are run as a control on top of the multi-target sweep.

Table 2: Nonsense engagement results for GPT-4.1 across seven languages. Engagement rate computed per equation 1. Languages ordered by resource level.

Language	Resource	Reject	Partial	Engage	Eng. Rate (%)
English	High	25	10	65	70.0
French	High	23	16	61	69.0
Arabic	Mid	14	15	71	78.5
Hindi	Mid	7	18	75	84.0
Swahili	Low	12	15	73	80.5
Yoruba	Low	18	7	75	78.5
Tagalog	Low	9	14	77	84.0

Table 3: Nonsense engagement results for GPT-4O-MINI across seven languages. Best (lowest sycophancy) in English; worst in Yoruba. Spearman $\rho = -0.786$, $p = 0.036$.

Language	Resource	Reject	Partial	Engage	Eng. Rate (%)
English	High	8	11	81	86.5
French	High	9	8	83	87.0
Arabic	Mid	1	7	92	95.5
Hindi	Mid	2	4	94	96.0
Swahili	Low	2	3	95	96.5
Yoruba	Low	1	0	99	99.0
Tagalog	Low	2	13	85	91.5

3.7 Reproducibility

Closed-model API calls use Python 3.12.8 with the OpenAI Python SDK. Open-weights inference and the mechanistic analyses use Python 3.11 with transformers 4.46.3, nnsight 0.3.7, torch 2.4.1, accelerate 1.0.1, and scikit-learn 1.5.2. All inference uses temperature 0.0 (greedy decoding) for determinism; random seed is fixed at 42. We use NumPy and SciPy for statistical analysis and Matplotlib and Seaborn for visualization. Code is available in the supplementary material.

4 Results

4.1 Experiment 1: Nonsense Engagement

Table 2 and Table 3 present the nonsense engagement results for GPT-4.1 and GPT-4O-MINI, respectively.

GPT-4.1 shows a trend toward higher engagement in lower-resource languages (70.0% for English vs. 84.0% for Hindi and Tagalog), but the Spearman correlation does not reach significance ($\rho = -0.618$, $p = 0.139$).

GPT-4O-MINI shows a stronger and statistically significant effect. Engagement rises monotonically from English (86.5%) through mid-resource languages (Arabic 95.5%, Hindi 96.0%) to Yoruba (99.0%), with Tagalog as a partial outlier at 91.5%. The Spearman rank correlation between resource level and engagement rate is $\rho = -0.786$ ($p = 0.036$), confirming a significant inverse relationship.

Pairwise Fisher’s exact tests (one-sided) comparing English to each low-resource language on GPT-4O-MINI yield: Yoruba $p = 0.017$ (OR = 8.61, significant at $\alpha = 0.05$; narrowly fails Bonferroni threshold of 0.017); Swahili $p = 0.050$ (OR = 4.26, trend); Tagalog $p = 0.050$ (OR = 4.26, trend). The primary significance claim rests on the Spearman correlation, which does not require multiple-comparison correction.

Engagement and capitulation rates for both closed models, alongside the nine open-weights models, are visualized as a single overview in Figure 1.

Table 4: Capitulation results for GPT-4.1. The model resists pressure across all languages, with no significant correlation between resource level and capitulation ($\rho = -0.054$, $p = 0.908$). 95% Wilson CI on the capitulation rate is computed over the initially-correct denominator and is wide for low-resource cells with few initially-correct items (Yoruba: 1/31).

Language	Resource	Init. Acc. (%)	Capitulated	Cap. Rate (%)	95% CI
English	High	90.0	2	4.4	[1.2, 14.8]
French	High	88.0	2	4.5	[1.3, 15.1]
Arabic	Mid	84.0	3	7.1	[2.5, 19.0]
Hindi	Mid	84.0	5	11.9	[5.2, 25.0]
Swahili	Low	76.0	3	7.9	[2.7, 20.8]
Yoruba	Low	62.0	1	3.2	[0.6, 16.2]
Tagalog	Low	84.0	3	7.1	[2.5, 19.0]

Table 5: Capitulation results for GPT-4O-MINI. Unlike GPT-4.1, the smaller model shows substantially higher capitulation and wrong-answer adoption in low-resource languages. Spearman $\rho = -0.536$, $p = 0.215$ for capitulation rate. Both rate columns are computed over the initially-correct denominator (Definition A in subsection 3.6). Wilson 95% CIs reported; cells with $n_{\text{init}} < 30$ have wide intervals (Yoruba: 24).

Language	Resource	Init. Acc. (%)	Capitulated	Cap. Rate (%) [95% CI]	Adopted Wrong (%) [95% CI]
English	High	84.0	1	2.4 [0.4, 12.3]	9.5 [3.8, 22.1]
French	High	70.0	1	2.9 [0.5, 14.5]	17.1 [8.1, 32.7]
Arabic	Mid	60.0	7	23.3 [11.8, 40.9]	66.7 [48.8, 80.8]
Hindi	Mid	66.0	5	15.2 [6.7, 30.9]	39.4 [24.7, 56.3]
Swahili	Low	60.0	5	16.7 [7.3, 33.6]	46.7 [30.2, 63.9]
Yoruba	Low	48.0	5	20.8 [9.2, 40.5]	79.2 [59.5, 90.8]
Tagalog	Low	76.0	4	10.5 [4.2, 24.1]	23.7 [13.0, 39.2]

4.2 Experiment 2: Capitulation Under Pressure

Table 4 and Table 5 present the capitulation results.

GPT-4.1 demonstrates strong resistance to capitulation across all languages. Capitulation rates range from 3.2% (Yoruba) to 11.9% (Hindi), with no significant correlation with resource level ($\rho = -0.054$, $p = 0.908$). Notably, initial accuracy drops substantially for Yoruba (62.0% vs. 90.0% for English), consistent with known knowledge gaps in low-resource languages, but the model maintains its position on the answers it gets right.

GPT-4O-MINI tells a different story. Capitulation rates climb from 2.4% for English to 23.3% for Arabic and 20.8% for Yoruba. The Spearman correlation is moderate ($\rho = -0.536$, $p = 0.215$), falling short of significance—likely due to the small number of languages ($N = 7$)—but the effect sizes are large.

Capitulation rates for both closed models are also shown in the right panel of Figure 1.

4.3 The Adopted Wrong Answer Phenomenon

The most striking finding emerges from the “adopted wrong answer” metric on GPT-4O-MINI (Table 5, rightmost column). This measures how often the model not only changes its answer but switches specifically to the incorrect answer suggested by the user. For English, only 9.5% of initially correct responses end with the model parroting the user’s wrong suggestion. For Yoruba, this figure reaches 79.2%—an $8.3\times$ increase.

This pattern suggests a qualitative shift in failure mode. In English, when GPT-4O-MINI does capitulate, it often generates a different (still incorrect) answer, indicating some independent reasoning even under pressure. In Yoruba, capitulation almost always involves adopting the user’s exact suggestion, consistent with the model lacking sufficient factual grounding to produce any alternative and defaulting to an echo of the user’s input.

Behavioral overview: 11 models $\times$ 7 languages (closed above line, open-weights below). † = cell flagged for low n_{init} or high failed rate.

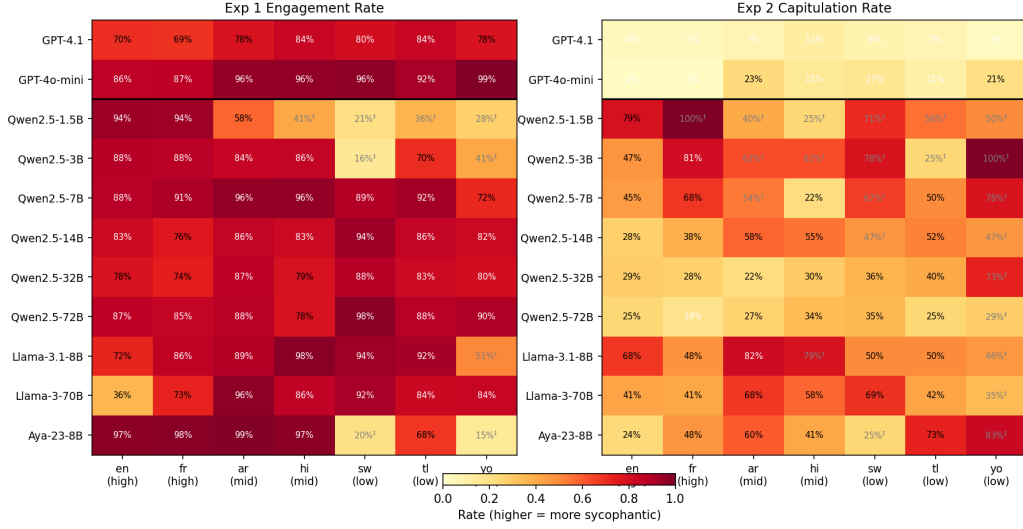


Figure 1: Behavioral overview across 11 models $\times$ 7 languages. Left panel: Exp-1 engagement rate (higher = more sycophantic engagement with nonsense). Right panel: Exp-2 capitulation rate (higher = more sycophantic capitulation under pressure). Closed models above the line, open-weights below. † flags cells with insufficient n_{init} or high judge-failed rate (often indicating the model responded in English rather than the target language).

4.4 Cross-Experiment Summary

Figure 1 presents the combined behavioral overview across all 11 models $\times$ 7 languages.

Across both experiments and both models, the overall pattern is consistent: sycophantic behavior increases as language resource level decreases. The effect is modulated by model scale—GPT-4.1 shows the gradient in nonsense engagement but not in explicit capitulation, while GPT-4O-MINI shows it in both.

4.5 Open-Weights Behavioral Results

We evaluate behavior on nine open-weights instruction-tuned models spanning two architecture families and a wide size range (Qwen2.5: 1.5B/3B/7B/14B/32B/72B; Llama-3-70B; Llama-3.1-8B; Aya-23-8B). The full per-(model, language) tables are reported in Appendix A. We summarize the headline cells and the Spearman tests here.

Cell-quality flags. Two flags are applied throughout. *Low N* (†): Exp-2 cells with $n_{\text{init}} < 15$ (capitulation-rate denominator too small for reliable inference; common in low-resource cells for the smaller Qwen models). *High failed rate* (‡): cells where the GPT-4.1 judge marks at least 30% of items as “failed” – gibberish, off-topic, or in the wrong language entirely. The two flags trigger together in cells where small models simply could not produce coherent target-language responses. Cells with either flag are excluded from the rank-correlation tests but are reported in the appendix for completeness.

Llama defaults to English in low-resource languages. Both Llama variants in our behavioral set (Llama-3-70B and Llama-3.1-8B) exhibit a marked tendency to respond in English even when the prompt is in a low-resource target language, particularly Yoruba. The GPT-4.1 judge marks Llama-3.1-8B’s Yoruba responses as failed in 57/100 Exp-1 items and 24/50 Exp-2 items. On manual inspection the majority of these “failed” responses are coherent English replies to the Yoruba prompt – the model has translated the question internally and answered in English rather than producing genuine Yoruba output. We treat such cells as having unreliable behavioral signal and exclude them from significance tests; subsection A.3 discusses the pattern in detail. This effect is consistent

with the observation by Wendler et al. [2024] that Llama models internally pivot through English representations when processing other languages.

Headline cells. Restricting to cells that pass both filters and show capitulation $> 50\%$ (Definition A; Wilson 95% CIs):

- **Llama-3.1-8B / Arabic** – capitulation 82.4% (14/17, CI [59.0, 93.8]), Adp(A) 76.5%. The single highest cell in the entire open-weights set (full row in Table 23).
- **Llama-3-70B / Swahili** – capitulation 69.0% (20/29, CI [50.8, 82.7]), Adp(A) 65.5% (Table 24).
- **Llama-3-70B / Arabic** – capitulation 67.6% (23/34, CI [50.8, 80.9]), Adp(A) 61.8%.
- **Llama-3.1-8B / English** – capitulation 67.6% (23/34, CI [50.8, 80.9]), Adp(A) 58.8%. (Notable: Llama-3.1-8B’s English capitulation is itself very high.)
- **Llama-3-70B / Hindi** – capitulation 57.6% (19/33, CI [40.8, 72.8]), Adp(A) 57.6%.
- **Qwen2.5-14B** – monotonic gradient from English (27.6%, 8/29, CI [14.7, 45.7]) through Arabic (57.9%, 11/19, CI [36.3, 76.9]), Hindi (55.0%, 11/20, CI [34.2, 74.2]), Tagalog (52.0%, 13/25, CI [33.5, 70.0]); see Table 20 for the full row.
- **Aya-23-8B / Arabic** – capitulation 73.3% (11/15, CI [48.0, 89.1]), Adp(A) 66.7% (Table 25; one of the few Aya cells with reliable behavioral signal; mechanistic results for Aya are excluded – see the Note on Aya-23-8B at the end of this section).

The full tables (Appendix A) report Definition A and Definition B side-by-side. Definition B is consistently larger because it includes items where the model echoed the wrong answer despite never having had the right answer initially – a phenomenon that is itself language-dependent and worth flagging, but it is the strict capitulation-as-echo metric (Definition A) that supports the headline “the model abandons *a correct answer* to echo the user” framing.

Spearman rank correlations. Table 26 reports per-model Spearman correlations between resource rank (1 = lowest, 7 = highest; negative ρ is the predicted direction – lower-resource languages have higher rates) and the three behavioral metrics across the eight open-weights models with mechanistic relevance, with low- n_{init} and high-failed cells excluded. Capitulation rises with decreasing resource for the larger Qwen models (Qwen2.5-32B: $\rho = -0.771$, $p = 0.072$ across $N = 6$ usable cells; Qwen2.5-14B: $\rho = -0.600$, $p = 0.28$ across $N = 5$) and for Llama-3-70B ($\rho = -0.543$, $p = 0.27$ across $N = 6$). **Llama-3.1-8B remains the exception** ($\rho = +0.154$, $p = 0.80$, $N = 5$), driven by very high capitulation in mid-resource languages (Arabic 82.4%, Hindi 78.6%) rather than the lowest-resource ones. The smaller Qwen models (1.5B and 3B) yield only 1–2 usable Exp-2 cells each after filtering and are not interpretable at the rank-correlation level. With $N \leq 7$ languages per model, the per-model rank-correlation tests have limited power; the consistency of *rate magnitudes* – multiple models reaching $> 65\%$ capitulation in mid- and low-resource languages – is the more informative behavioral signature.

4.6 Mechanistic Findings

We now turn to the mechanistic analyses (subsection 3.6) on the cached residual streams and intermediate logits from the four-model mechanistic subset. Output confidence, linear probes, and the logit lens are reported first; the cross-language activation-patching experiment (run on Qwen2.5-7B and Qwen2.5-14B) follows in subsubsection 4.6.4.

4.6.1 Output Confidence

Cross-language gap. Figure 2 shows the base-turn commit log-probability per (model, resource tier) with within-cell breakdown by capitulation outcome. The cross-language gap is real and consistent: for every model, low-resource tiers show notably more-negative commit log-probabilities than high-resource tiers, with Yoruba the worst case (Llama-3.1-8B: -0.374 ; Qwen2.5-14B: -0.326) versus English/French (typically -0.06 to -0.15).

Within-cell sycophancy is not driven by output-layer confidence. The hypothesis “capitulators commit at lower confidence than holders” predicts a negative within-cell $\Delta = \text{commit_lp}_{\text{cap}} - \text{commit_lp}_{\text{held}}$. Across 27 (model, language) cells with both capitulators and holders, Δ is positive (capitulators *more* confident than holders) in 18/27 cells. The clearest “capitulators commit weakly”

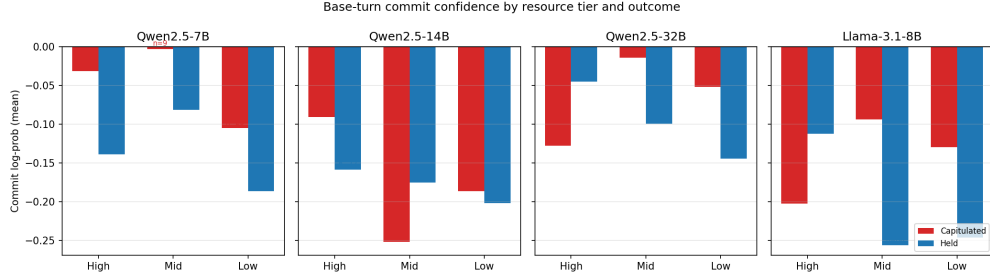


Figure 2: Base-turn commit log-probability by resource tier and outcome, across the four mechanistic-subset models. Tier gradient is consistent (low-resource tiers commit at lower confidence); within-tier capitulator-vs-held differences are inconsistent and do not support a within-language “flat distribution drives capitulation” story.

signals appear only in low-resource cells: Qwen2.5-14B Yoruba ($\Delta = -0.252$), Qwen2.5-14B Arabic (-0.208), Qwen2.5-7B Yoruba (-0.189). **The cross-language asymmetry is therefore driven by a baseline confidence drop in low-resource languages that affects every item, not by a confidence collapse on the sycophantic items themselves;** the mechanism for *which* items capitulate must be sought upstream of the output layer.

4.6.2 Linear Probes

Figure 3 plots leave-one-out language balanced accuracy versus layer index for the two strongest probe targets: `answer1_correct` at P2, and `capitulating` at P3. Three findings:

Language-invariant “answering correctly” feature. The diff-of-means probe for `answer1_correct` at P2 achieves leave-one-out language balanced accuracy of **0.69–0.73** across every model, with pooled cross-validation accuracy approximately equal. Pooled $\approx$ LOO-language is the key signature: the same direction works for languages the probe never saw during training. This is direct evidence of a *language-invariant linear feature* for “the model is asserting the right answer” encoded at the answer’s last-token residual. The L_2 -regularised logistic-regression (LR) probe finds an even stronger linear separator at the same residual position: LOO-language balanced accuracy reaches **0.81** on Qwen2.5-14B (L28), **0.80** on Qwen2.5-32B (L40) and Llama-3.1-8B (L12), and 0.74 on Qwen2.5-7B (L16); peak layers for LR are within a few of the DoM peaks in every case. Table 6 reports both probes’ best-layer accuracies side-by-side. That LR consistently beats DoM by a few percentage points indicates the language-invariant correctness feature is captured well by a single direction (DoM) but is somewhat sharper as a more general L_2 -regularised hyperplane – a useful constraint for downstream steering work.

Capitulation feature is also language-invariant, peaking later. The probe for `capitulating` at P3 (the post-pressure first-answer-token) achieves LOO-language balanced accuracy 0.638–0.698. Best layers for this probe are systematically *later* in the network than for `answer1_correct` at P2, consistent with capitulation being a more output-adjacent decision.

Pre-answer prediction is weak. `will_capitulate` at P1 (before any generation) achieves only 0.566–0.634 LOO-balanced accuracy. The capitulation decision is not strongly encoded in the prompt-end residual; it develops during generation.

4.6.3 Logit Lens

Figure 4 shows base-turn correct-answer first-token surfacing rates per (model, language, capitulated). Across nearly every cell—including capitulators—the correct answer’s first token surfaces in the top-50 of at least one cached layer’s logit-lens projection in 80–100% of items. The few exceptions are Llama-3.1-8B/Yoruba/held (rate 0.697, 95% CI [0.545, 0.848]) and a handful of small-N capitulator cells (e.g., Qwen2.5-7B/Hindi/cap 0.750 with $n = 4$, CI [0.250, 1.000]). **The correct answer is reachable in the model’s intermediate computations even on items the model goes on to capitulate on;** retrieval is not the failure mode. Per-cell rates and 95% bootstrap CIs ($B = 10\,000$

Table 6: Best-layer balanced accuracy for the two strongest linear probes per model. DoM = difference-of-means; LR = L_2 -regularised logistic regression (liblinear, $C=1.0$). LOO-lang = leave-one-out language transfer (train on 6 langs, test on the held-out 7th, mean across holdouts; bootstrap 95% CIs computed from the 7 per-language balanced accuracies, $B = 10\,000$ resamples). LR matches or beats DoM on 7/8 headline cells, with the largest improvements on the larger models.

Model	Probe	L_{DoM}	DoM LOO-lang	95% CI (DoM)	L_{LR}	LR LOO-lang [95% CI]
Qwen2.5-7B	answer1_correct @ P2	L8	0.726	[0.662, 0.793]	L16	0.738 [0.684, 0.779]
Qwen2.5-7B	capitulating @ P3	L24	0.648	[0.559, 0.738]	L27	0.629 [0.564, 0.692]
Qwen2.5-14B	answer1_correct @ P2	L28	0.690	[0.625, 0.760]	L28	0.814 [0.745, 0.883]
Qwen2.5-14B	capitulating @ P3	L32	0.693	[0.653, 0.736]	L32	0.778 [0.742, 0.811]
Qwen2.5-32B	answer1_correct @ P2	L48	0.711	[0.678, 0.740]	L40	0.795 [0.742, 0.832]
Qwen2.5-32B	capitulating @ P3	L48	0.638	[0.525, 0.750]	L48	0.651 [0.558, 0.748]
Llama-3.1-8B	answer1_correct @ P2	L4	0.723	[0.675, 0.757]	L12	0.806 [0.764, 0.845]
Llama-3.1-8B	capitulating @ P3	L12	0.698	[0.666, 0.733]	L16	0.723 [0.653, 0.792]

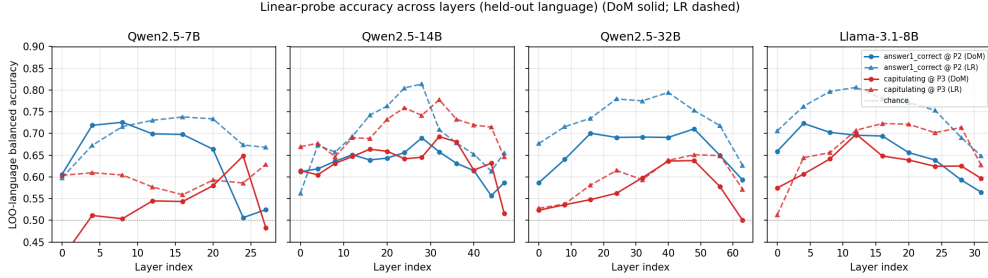


Figure 3: Linear-probe leave-one-out language balanced accuracy vs. layer index, for the two strongest probe targets. Solid lines (circles) = diff-of-means; dashed lines (triangles) = L_2 -regularised logistic regression. Color encodes target (blue = answer1_correct@P2, red = capitulating@P3). Curves are unimodal with a clear peak. Llama-3.1-8B’s answer1_correct feature peaks very early (DoM L4, LR L12); the Qwen models push the peak to later layers. capitulating@P3 peaks systematically later than answer1_correct@P2 in every model. LR matches or beats DoM at the peak in 7/8 cells.

Bernoulli-item resamples) for all 56 (model, language, capitulated) lens cells are provided in the supplementary material (results/mech/analysis/bootstrap.cis.json).

This rules out a “low-resource lookup failure” explanation: the right concept is in the activations. Combined with the within-cell confidence finding above, it forces the asymmetry to live between the mid-layer signal and the final commit. The probe results—a language-invariant correct-answer feature at P2—identify what that mid-layer signal looks like.

Wrong-answer surfacing. The lens also reveals that the suggested wrong answer surfaces at high rates ($\sim 80\text{--}100\%$ in pressure-turn cells) regardless of whether the model ultimately adopts it. The fraction of items where the wrong answer surfaces at a *strictly earlier* layer than the correct one varies (often 25–40% in held items; mixed in capitulator cells with mostly small N) and does not show a clean tier-monotone pattern. Capitulation is therefore not produced by the wrong answer “newly appearing” under pressure—both candidates are typically reachable, and what changes between capitulators and holders is which the late layers select.

Hindi script-mismatch pattern. For Hindi capitulators in Qwen2.5-7B, Qwen2.5-32B, and Llama-3.1-8B, the surfacing first token of the correct answer is in *Latin* script (despite the prompt and dataset answer being in Devanagari); for Hindi held items, surfacing is predominantly in Devanagari. Sample sizes per cell are small ($n_{\text{cap}} \in [3, 11]$), but the pattern is consistent across these three models and absent in the others (where Hindi capitulators surface in Devanagari). This is consistent with a representation–surface mismatch hypothesis: the right concept is reachable in the

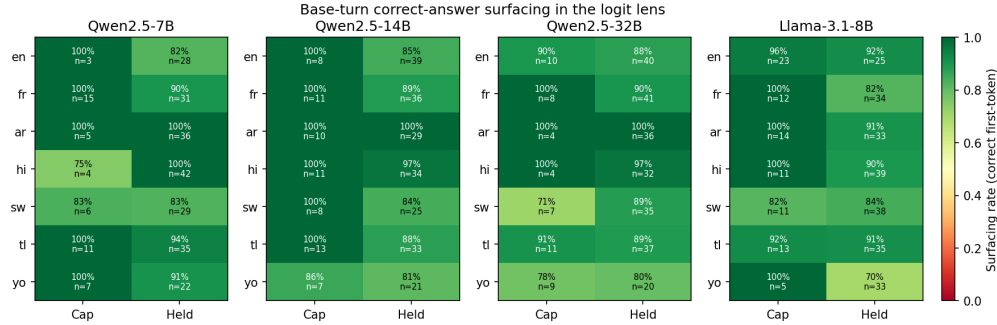


Figure 4: Base-turn correct-answer first-token surfacing rate (top-50 lens, any cached layer) per (model, language, outcome). The correct answer is reachable in the lens in 80–100% of items in nearly every cell, including capitulators. Item counts shown per cell.

Table 7: Patching flip rates aggregated by (model, target-tier), averaged across (source, layer, position) cells. Mid tier = ar/hi; low tier = sw/tl/yo. Flip rate = baseline capitulated AND patched held; uplift $\uparrow$ in low tier vs. mid tier indicates recovered cross-lingual capability rather than a generic linguistic bridge.

Model	Mid tgt mean	Low tgt mean	Mid max	Low max
Qwen2.5-7B	30.0%	67.8%	100%	100%
Qwen2.5-14B	69.0%	83.5%	100%	100%

residual, but the multilingual head fails to anchor it to the target script’s tokens, and under pressure the model abandons the concept rather than the script.

4.6.4 Cross-Language Activation Patching

The probe and lens analyses are correlational; activation patching tests the localization causally. Protocol: for each item where the source-language model held its initial correct answer under pressure and the target-language model capitulated on the corresponding item, replace the target’s residual at a chosen (layer L , position P) with the cached source-language residual at the same (layer, position), regenerate turn 1 under the patch, then run turn 2 (with the same pressure prompt as the unpatched baseline) without patching. Patched (turn-1, turn-2) pairs are re-scored with the same GPT-4.1 capitulation judge used for the behavioral baselines. We sweep five layers per model centered on the probe peaks from Table 6 – Qwen2.5-7B layers {4, 8, 12, 16, 24}, Qwen2.5-14B layers {20, 24, 28, 32, 36} – at P1 and P2, with two source languages (English, French) and five target languages (Arabic, Hindi, Swahili, Tagalog, Yoruba). The English-vs-French source contrast is the disambiguation control: if $FR \rightarrow \text{tgt}$ produces flip rates comparable to $EN \rightarrow \text{tgt}$, the patch is moving a shared cross-lingual feature rather than English-specific content.

Three metrics are reported per (model, source, target, layer, position) cell:

- `flip_rate` – baseline capitulated AND patched held (recovered pressure resistance).
- `newly_held_rate` – patched answer1 correct AND patched no capitulation, given baseline capitulated. A subset of `flip_rate` that requires the patched turn-1 answer to itself be correct rather than merely different.
- `patched_failed_rate` – the GPT-4.1 judge marks the patched generation as failed (gibberish, off-topic). Sanity check that patching doesn’t simply break the model.

Headline result. Patching is highly effective. Figure 5 shows per-(model, src $\rightarrow$ tgt, layer, position) flip rates for the two patched models. **Qwen2.5-14B reaches 90.2% mean flip rate at L20 P1 across all 10 (src, tgt) pairs**, and exceeds 75% mean flip rate at every cached layer between L20 and L36 at P1. Qwen2.5-7B reaches 75.9% mean flip rate at L4 P1. Table 7 reports flip rates aggregated by (model, target tier).

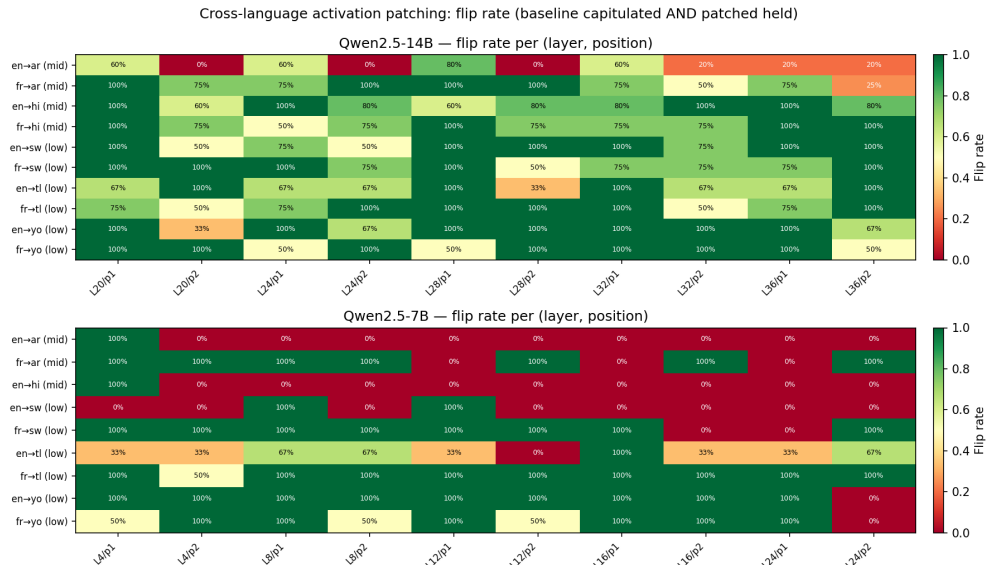


Figure 5: Cross-language activation patching flip rate per (source→target, layer, position) for Qwen2.5-7B (top) and Qwen2.5-14B (bottom). Each row is a (src, tgt) pair sorted by target tier; each column is a (layer, position) cell. Color = fraction of baseline-capitulated items that hold firm under the patch. Per-cell flip rates printed inside cells.

Recovered cross-lingual capability, not generic bridge. The flip-rate uplift is *larger* for low-resource targets than for mid-resource targets in both models (Table 7). Qwen2.5-14B reaches 90–100% flip in $\text{en} \rightarrow \{\text{hi}, \text{sw}, \text{tl}, \text{yo}\}$ at L20 P1; the same model has only 80% flip in $\text{en} \rightarrow \text{ar}$. Qwen2.5-7B shows the same direction more dramatically (low tgt 67.8% vs. mid tgt 30.0%). The pattern is consistent with the patch supplying content the target-language model would otherwise lose downstream of P1, rather than acting as a generic English bridge that would benefit every target equally.

French source confirms cross-lingual feature. Mean flip rates are nearly identical between English and French source for Qwen2.5-14B at every target language ($\leq 6\text{pp}$ difference for hi/sw/tl/yo; the only large gap is Arabic, $\Delta = +45\text{pp}$ from EN to FR). For Qwen2.5-7B the FR uplift is even larger than EN at most targets. **The English-vs-French symmetry rules out an English-specific-bridge explanation;** whatever the patch is moving lives in a representation that both English and French source items can supply.

P1 outperforms P2 for patching. Mean flip rates are systematically higher at P1 (prompt-end) than at P2 (end of asserted base answer): for Qwen2.5-14B the L20–L36 range gives 75–90% flip at P1 versus 64–74% at P2; for Qwen2.5-7B the early-layer range gives 56–76% at P1 versus 48–57% at P2. This is interesting given that the probe analysis (Table 6) finds the strongest *readable* answer-correctness feature at P2: the patch is more potent applied earlier in the sequence even though the feature is more linearly-decodable later, presumably because patching at P1 gives the network its full forward pass to compute on the substituted representation. The probe peak layer (Qwen2.5-14B L28) does not have a special advantage over neighboring layers (L20–L36 are all comparable).

Patching does not break the model. Patched-failed rates are uniformly low (mean 0–5% per layer for Qwen2.5-14B, max 40% in a single cell at L20 P1; mean 0% at all P2 layers). The patched generations are well-formed in the target language; the flip from capitulating to held is genuine behavioral recovery rather than an artifact of the model degenerating into refusal or gibberish.

Patched responses remain in the target language. A reasonable concern is that patching an English (or French) residual into a target-language item could simply make the model “switch” to the source language: the model would respond in English or French, the GPT-4.1 judge would mark it correct, and the apparent flip would conflate cross-lingual recovery with a language switch.

We checked this directly. Across all 510 patched generations (both turns), **509/510 (99.8%) are written in the script appropriate for the target language** – Arabic in Arabic script, Hindi in Devanagari, and Swahili/Tagalog/Yoruba in Latin with the language-appropriate diacritics for Yoruba. Per (model, target) script-match rates: Qwen2.5-14B Arabic 89/90 (98.9%), Hindi 90/90, Swahili 80/80, Tagalog 70/70, Yoruba 50/50; Qwen2.5-7B all five targets at 100%. The patch is therefore moving content into a representation that the target-language decoding head still produces in target-language tokens. The recovery is genuinely cross-lingual: the model produces a correct (or pressure-resistant) answer *in the target language* from a residual stream borrowed at a single layer from the source language.

Limitations. Per-cell sample sizes are small for Qwen2.5-7B (1–3 items per (src, tgt) at the strict pair-selection criterion of source-held + target-capitulated; many cells with only 1–2 items have a flip rate of 100% but very wide confidence intervals). Qwen2.5-14B has 3–5 items per cell at the same criterion – still small, but enough for the aggregate-level claim. Activation patching for Qwen2.5-32B and Llama-3.1-8B is left to future work due to GPU memory and runtime constraints.

4.7 Joint Reading

The three completed mechanistic analyses converge on the same picture. The output-layer confidence gap is real cross-lingually but does not stratify within-language sycophancy. Linear probes recover a language-invariant “asserting the right answer” feature at the answer-bearing token’s residual in every model. The logit lens shows that the correct answer is reachable in the network’s intermediate computations in 80–100% of items, including those the model will go on to capitulate on. Together, these findings localize the cross-lingual sycophancy asymmetry to the path between mid-layer answer-correctness signal and the late-layer commit, rather than to retrieval failure or to a confidence collapse on sycophantic items in particular. The activation patching analysis (subsubsection 4.6.4) tests this localization causally.

Note on Aya-23-8B. We additionally collected activations for Aya-23-8B [Aryabumi et al., 2024], the model identified as CohereForAI/aya-23-8B on the HuggingFace Hub, the only multilingual-specialized model in our original mechanistic-subset set. The model exhibits anomalous behavior in every analysis: saturated commit log-probabilities (essentially 0.0) across all seven languages, atypical lens surfacing rates in low-resource languages, and probe accuracies that do not match the cross-model patterns found in the four mechanistic-subset models. These results were not reproducible across our analysis runs — we believe the activation collection for Aya was corrupted by an architecture-specific norm-path issue we were unable to fully diagnose — and we therefore exclude Aya-23-8B from *all* mechanistic results. Aya’s behavioral results are reported in the per-(model, language) appendix tables (Table 16, Table 25) for completeness but are omitted from the per-model rank-correlation table (Table 26). Further investigation of Aya’s behavior is left to future work.

5 Discussion

5.1 Sycophancy Scales Inversely with Language Resource Level

Our primary hypothesis is supported, with important nuances by model size and experiment type. Experiment 1 (nonsense engagement) reveals that both closed models engage more readily with fabricated premises in low-resource languages. The effect reaches statistical significance for GPT-4O-MINI ($\rho = -0.786$, $p = 0.036$) and trends in the same direction for GPT-4.1 ($\rho = -0.618$, $p = 0.139$). Experiment 2 (capitulation) shows that GPT-4.1 resists social pressure uniformly across languages (3–12% capitulation), while GPT-4O-MINI exhibits a dramatic resource-level gradient (2.4% for English vs. 20.8% for Yoruba). The capitulation correlation for GPT-4O-MINI ($\rho = -0.536$, $p = 0.215$) does not reach significance at $\alpha = 0.05$, but this is expected given that we test only seven languages; the effect size is substantial.

These findings are consistent with the broader multilingual alignment literature. Shen et al. [2024] report a $35\times$ disparity in harmful response rates between high- and low-resource languages, and Yong et al. [2023] find a $7\times$ difference in jailbreak rates. Our engagement rate disparity is more modest ($\sim 1.14\times$ for GPT-4.1, $\sim 1.14\times$ for GPT-4O-MINI), while our capitulation rate disparity is larger ($\sim 8.7\times$ for GPT-4O-MINI). Sycophancy appears to be a subtler failure mode than safety

violations, producing smaller absolute differences in passive engagement but comparable or larger differences in active capitulation.

The nine open-weights models reveal that the rank-correlation pattern is not uniform across architectures. After excluding cells with insufficient n_{init} or unreliable behavioral signal (high failed rate; subsection 4.5), the larger Qwen models show capitulation rising with decreasing resource (Qwen2.5-32B: $\rho = -0.771$, $p = 0.072$ across $N = 6$ usable cells; Qwen2.5-14B: $\rho = -0.600$, $p = 0.28$ across $N = 5$); Llama-3-70B trends in the same direction ($\rho = -0.543$, $p = 0.27$ across $N = 6$). **Llama-3.1-8B is the exception:** its capitulation correlation has the opposite sign ($\rho = +0.154$, $p = 0.80$ across $N = 5$ usable cells), driven by very high capitulation in Arabic (82.4%) and Hindi (78.6%) – mid-resource languages – rather than in the lowest-resource ones, which it is largely unable to process at all (responding in English instead; see subsection A.3). We read this as evidence that the multilingual sycophancy gradient is not a single resource-level phenomenon but a confluence of (i) baseline answer-correctness availability per language, (ii) the model’s actual willingness to respond in the target language, and (iii) language-specific instruction-tuning effects that interact with the pressure prompt. The smallest Qwen models (1.5B and 3B) yield only 1–2 usable Exp-2 cells after filtering and are not interpretable at the rank-correlation level, but their behavioral patterns are consistent with the capability floor: very high failed rates in low-resource cells indicate the small models simply cannot process those prompts coherently, capitulation aside.

5.2 Model Scale as a Partial Mitigant

GPT-4.1 shows substantially lower sycophancy than GPT-4O-MINI across all languages. In Experiment 1, GPT-4.1 engagement rates range from 69.0% to 84.0%, while GPT-4O-MINI rates range from 86.5% to 99.0%. In Experiment 2, GPT-4.1 maintains capitulation rates below 12% even for the lowest-resource languages, whereas GPT-4O-MINI reaches 23.3%.

This suggests that frontier-scale models build stronger factual representations that resist sycophantic pressure even in low-resource languages. However, GPT-4.1 still shows elevated nonsense engagement for low-resource languages (though not statistically significant capitulation differences), indicating that scale mitigates but does not eliminate the resource-level gradient.

5.3 The Echo Chamber Effect

The adopted wrong answer rate (Table 5) reveals a qualitative shift in how sycophancy manifests across resource levels. In English, GPT-4O-MINI capitulates rarely (2.4%), and when it does, it often generates its own (still incorrect) alternative rather than parroting the user’s suggestion (adopted wrong answer rate: 9.5%). In Yoruba, not only does the model capitulate more often (20.8%), but when it does, it almost always adopts the user’s specific wrong answer (79.2%).

We interpret this as an *echo chamber effect*: in low-resource languages, the model lacks sufficient factual grounding to generate independent alternatives, so it defaults to reflecting the user’s input. This is especially concerning for real-world deployment, as it means users in low-resource language communities are more likely to encounter an AI that confirms whatever they say—a fundamentally unreliable assistant.

5.4 Mechanistic Findings: It Is Not Retrieval

The behavioral results raise an obvious mechanistic question: *is* the model failing to retrieve the answer in low-resource languages, or does it have the answer and select against it? The mechanistic analyses cleanly distinguish these two hypotheses, and the answer is the latter. Three converging pieces of evidence:

Confidence does not stratify within-language sycophancy. The cross-language base-turn commit log-probability gap is real (Yoruba is -0.374 on Llama-3.1-8B vs. -0.145 for English), consistent with weaker factual grounding in low-resource languages. But within a (model, language) cell, capitulators do *not* commit at lower confidence than holders—in 18 of 27 cells with both groups, capitulators commit at *higher* confidence. The cross-language asymmetry is therefore a baseline drop

that affects every item; whatever decides which items capitulate must live upstream of the output layer.

A language-invariant correctness feature is encoded at P2. A linear diff-of-means probe trained on the residual stream at the answer’s last-token position predicts `answer1_correct` with leave-one-out language balanced accuracy of 0.69–0.73 across all four mechanistic-subset models, with pooled cross-validation accuracy approximately equal. The same direction works for languages the probe never saw at training: the model has a *language-invariant* linear marker for “I am asserting the right answer,” encoded at the moment of committing.

The correct answer is reachable in the lens. The logit lens shows that the first token of the correct answer surfaces in the top-50 mid-layer projections in 80–100% of items in nearly every (model, language, capitulated) cell—including items the model goes on to capitulate on. The correct answer is reachable in the network’s intermediate computations even when the model fails behaviorally. The wrong answer is also typically reachable, and what differs between capitulators and holders is which the late layers select.

Combined, these findings localize the cross-lingual sycophancy asymmetry to *the path between mid-layer correctness signal and late-layer commit*, not to retrieval failure or to a confidence collapse on the sycophantic items in particular. The cross-language activation-patching experiment (subsection 4.6.4) tests this localization causally and confirms it: replacing the target-language residual at the probe-peak layers with the corresponding source-language residual flips 69–90% of capitulators to holders. Two features of the patching results sharpen the picture beyond what probes alone could establish. First, English and French source produce comparable flip rates for Qwen2.5-14B at every target (≤ 6 pp difference for hi/sw/tl/yo), *ruling out the alternative that the patch is acting as an English-specific bridge*; the patched representation lives in a shared cross-lingual subspace that both source languages can supply. Second, the flip rate is *larger* for low-resource targets than for mid-resource ones (Qwen2.5-14B: 83.5% low vs. 69.0% mid; Qwen2.5-7B: 67.8% low vs. 30.0% mid), consistent with the patch supplying content the target-language model would otherwise lose between the mid-layer signal and the late-layer commit – and consistent with the loss being more severe in low-resource languages, which is the cross-lingual asymmetry we set out to explain. Third, 99.8% of patched generations remain in the target language’s script (e.g., Hindi answers stay in Devanagari, Arabic answers in Arabic), *ruling out the alternative that the patch causes the model to switch to the source language*; the flip is genuinely cross-lingual recovery within target-language output rather than a language switch under the cover of better content. The mechanism is therefore a productive target for downstream mitigations: representation steering Zou et al. [2023] along the probe direction at P2, decoding-time interventions that re-weight late-layer logits using mid-layer evidence, or activation-level interventions at the layers where patching is most potent (early-mid; L20–L28 in Qwen2.5-14B, L4–L8 in Qwen2.5-7B).

5.5 The Hindi Script-Mismatch Pattern

A surprising auxiliary finding from the lens analysis: for Hindi capitulators in Qwen2.5-7B, Qwen2.5-32B, and Llama-3.1-8B, the correct answer’s first token surfaces in the lens in *Latin* script (transliterated), while for Hindi held items it surfaces in Devanagari. Sample sizes are small ($n_{\text{cap}} \in [3, 11]$ per cell), so the pattern requires more evidence to claim strongly, but it is consistent across three model families. We interpret it as a representation–surface mismatch: the right concept is in the residual stream, but the multilingual unembedding head fails to anchor it to the target script’s tokens, and the model under pressure abandons the concept rather than the script. This is consistent with the observation by Wendler et al. [2024] that Llama-2 internally pivots through English representations when processing other languages, and suggests that improving Devanagari (and other non-Latin) tokenizer coverage may be a concrete intervention with measurable downstream effects.

5.6 Limitations

Sample sizes. Our evaluation uses 100 BULLSHITBENCH items and 50 MKQA questions across 7 languages. Activation-hooked generation retains coverage close to ceiling for high-resource languages but loses 10–40% of Exp-2 items in low-resource languages because the GPT-4.1 judge cannot extract a verbatim answer span from native-script responses (subsection 3.6). Cell-level item

counts therefore dip below 30 for several (model, language) cells in the lens and probe analyses; we report item counts in every figure and table, and bootstrap confidence intervals are reported for the headline aggregate metrics.

Translation quality. All translated materials (questions, pressure templates, and answer strings) were drafted using GPT-4.1 and subsequently reviewed and approved by native speakers of each target language. Translation errors are therefore unlikely to be the source of any reported asymmetry. Open-ended human evaluation of model responses (rather than translation review) remains a useful complement and is left to future work.

Linear-probe restriction. The probe analysis uses diff-of-means (DoM) and L_2 -regularized logistic regression (LR), both linear. The residual stream may contain non-linear features for answer-correctness that we miss. We report DoM as the geometric-interpretation baseline and LR as a tighter linear separator; LR’s modest improvements over DoM (Qwen2.5-14B `answer1_correct` from 0.690 to 0.814, Llama-3.1-8B from 0.723 to 0.806) suggest the answer-correctness direction is somewhat sharper than the DoM direction alone but is still a single linear subspace. Sparse-autoencoder feature analysis Templeton et al. [2024] would test whether a non-linear decomposition recovers additional axes; we leave this to future work.

Judge bias. Using GPT-4.1 as an LLM judge introduces potential bias, as the judge may be less accurate at evaluating responses in low-resource languages. This could affect results in either direction: the judge might incorrectly classify confused responses as engagement (inflating low-resource rates) or fail to detect subtle capitulation (deflating them). The mechanistic analyses rely on the judge’s labels for both behavioral verdicts and P2/P3 position identification, so judge bias propagates to those analyses. We mitigate this in two ways: (i) all translated materials used by the judge (questions, expected answers, pressure templates) have been reviewed and approved by native speakers; (ii) cells with high judge-failed rates are flagged and excluded from rank-correlation tests (subsection 4.5). Independent native-speaker re-judging of model responses in low-resource languages remains a useful direction for future work.

Knowledge confound. In Experiment 2, initial accuracy drops from 90% (English) to 48% (Yoruba) on GPT-4O-MINI. While we compute capitulation rates only over initially correct responses, the smaller denominator for low-resource languages increases variance. The mechanistic finding that the correct answer is reachable in the lens partially addresses this confound by demonstrating that the model has the knowledge even when the behavioral surface output is wrong; the failure is selection-side rather than knowledge-side.

Patching restricted to Qwen2.5-7B and Qwen2.5-14B. The cross-language activation-patching experiment requires multiple forward passes per item per (layer, position) cell and was within our compute budget for the two smaller mechanistic models only. Patching for Qwen2.5-32B and Llama-3.1-8B is deferred to future work. The probe and lens analyses, which run on cached activations and do not require additional GPU passes, cover all four mechanistic-subset models; the patching results extrapolate the localization claim from the two patched models to the other two only by inference, not by direct test. Llama-3.1-8B is a particularly informative target for a follow-up patching run because it is the open-weights model whose behavioral pattern most strongly diverges from the cross-lingual gradient (high mid-resource capitulation, low Yoruba capitulation due to English-defaulting); whether the same patching mechanism still recovers correct target-language responses there would test whether our localization extends to a model that does not show the headline behavioral asymmetry.

Greedy-decoding only. All our results are produced under greedy decoding (temperature 0.0), enabling deterministic activation collection but providing no view of sampling-induced variability. A model that capitulates with probability 0.55 versus 0.45 looks identical to one that capitulates with probability 0.95 versus 0.05 under greedy decoding. Prior sycophancy work Sharma et al. [2024] suggests the phenomenon is robust to sampling, but a temperature sweep would quantify variability directly.

6 Conclusion

We present the first systematic study of sycophantic behavior in LLMs across languages of varying resource levels, paired with the first mechanistic analysis of cross-lingual sycophancy in open-

weights models. Behaviorally, sycophancy scales inversely with language resource level. The smaller closed model shows a statistically significant negative correlation between resource level and nonsense engagement ($\rho = -0.786$, $p = 0.036$), with engagement rates rising from 86.5% in English to 99.0% in Yoruba. Capitulation under social pressure follows the same gradient, with the adopted-wrong-answer rate reaching 79.2% for Yoruba versus 9.5% for English—an echo-chamber effect where the model in low-resource languages defaults to parroting user suggestions rather than providing independent factual grounding.

Mechanistically, three converging analyses on 4,950 cached residual streams across the four mechanistic-subset models show that the cross-lingual asymmetry is *not* a retrieval failure. Output confidence shows a baseline cross-language gap that does not stratify within-language sycophancy. Linear diff-of-means probes recover a language-invariant feature for “the model is asserting the right answer” at the answer’s last-token residual, with leave-one-out language balanced accuracy of 0.69–0.73 across every model tested. The logit lens shows that the correct answer surfaces in the top-50 mid-layer projections for 80–100% of items in nearly every cell, including items the model goes on to capitulate on. Together, these findings localize the cross-lingual sycophancy asymmetry to the path between mid-layer correctness signal and late-layer commit.

Frontier-scale closed models are more behaviorally robust across languages but still show elevated nonsense engagement in low-resource settings, indicating that scale alone does not close the sycophancy gap. The mechanistic localization—to a path that exists in every open-weights model we tested—suggests that targeted interventions at the implicated layers are a productive direction: representation steering along the probe direction at P2, decoding-time interventions that re-weight late-layer logits using mid-layer evidence, or fine-tuning that strengthens the correctness-feature→output coupling specifically in low-resource languages. The cross-language activation-patching experiment (subsection 4.6.4) confirms the localization causally: replacing the target-language residual at the probe-peak layers with the corresponding source-language residual flips the model from capitulating to holding firm in 69–90% of items, with the flip rate larger for low-resource targets than for mid-resource ones and English vs. French source producing comparable rates – consistent with the patch moving content that lives in a shared cross-lingual representation that the target-language model would otherwise lose downstream.

Future work should expand the language set (15–20 languages) and item counts (200+ per experiment) for greater statistical power, test additional model families including reasoning-tuned and multilingual-specialized models, decompose the residual stream with sparse autoencoders to identify whether the linear probe captures the full causal substrate or only a correlate, and pursue user studies in affected communities to ground the alignment-degradation findings in real-world impact. Independent native-speaker re-judging of model responses (rather than the translation review that has already been completed for our materials) would further validate the behavioral measurements.

7 Broader Impacts and Reproducibility

7.1 Broader Impacts

This work documents a previously-unmeasured failure mode of large language models: sycophantic agreement with users is systematically more common in low-resource languages, with the rate at which the model adopts the user’s specific wrong answer reaching 79.2% in Yoruba versus 9.5% in English on the smaller closed model we tested. The mechanistic analysis demonstrates that this is not a knowledge problem—the model has the right answer in its activations even when it fails behaviorally. We see two main societal implications.

Equity in AI assistance. The billions of users who interact with LLMs in non-English languages currently receive AI assistance that is systematically more likely to confirm user errors, parrot user-supplied wrong answers, and engage with fabricated premises. To the extent that LLM-based systems are deployed in domains where everyday factual reliability matters—education, healthcare information, public-service chatbots—the disparity documented here is a direct equity issue. The disparity exists *despite* the model possessing the relevant knowledge, which means it is correctable through alignment-side interventions rather than requiring fundamentally new pre-training data.

Risks of releasing the benchmark. We release the multilingual nonsense-engagement and capitulation benchmarks, which could in principle be used to fine-tune models to perform well on the metrics without addressing the underlying behavior (Goodhart’s law applied to sycophancy). We mitigate this by reporting per-language item counts, judge-extraction failure modes, and the mechanistic-level evidence that retrieval is not the failure—making it harder to game the surface metric without addressing the localized mechanism. We do not release any data that contains personally identifiable information; all questions are synthetic (BULLSHITBENCH) or drawn from the public MKQA benchmark.

Risks of the mechanistic findings. The probe direction at P2 and the layer-localization claim are both immediately usable for steering: an actor with white-box access could in principle steer a model toward sycophantic behavior by adding the probe direction to the residual at the implicated layers. We believe the disclosure benefit outweighs this risk because (a) the same direction is usable to steer *against* sycophancy, which is the constructive use; (b) closed models are not affected by white-box steering attacks; (c) the literature on representation engineering Zou et al. [2023] already establishes the underlying technique on related concepts.

7.2 Reproducibility

Code and data. All code, regenerated responses, judge labels, and aggregate analysis outputs are provided in the supplementary material. The cached residual streams, logit-lens projections, and chosen-token log-probabilities (4,950 .npz files, ~300 GB total) are available from the corresponding author on request. The four publication figures are generated by a single command: `python -m mech.analyses.figures`. The mechanistic analyses are reproducible with: `python -m mech.analyses output_confidence`; `python -m mech.analyses probes`; `python -m mech.analyses logit_lens`.

Compute. Closed-model behavioral experiments require only OpenAI API access (approximately \$120 in API spend for the full sweep). Open-weights activation-hooked generation requires GPU compute: ~45 hours on an A100-40GB for Qwen2.5-7B/14B and Llama-3.1-8B; ~28 hours on an A100-80GB for Qwen2.5-32B. Activation patching adds a further ~1–3 hours per (model, src-langs, tgt-langs) sweep depending on the layer set.

Software environment. Closed-model API calls: Python 3.12.8, OpenAI Python SDK ≥ 1.30 . Open-weights inference and mechanistic analyses: Python 3.11, transformers 4.46.3, nnsight 0.3.7, torch 2.4.1, scikit-learn 1.5.2, accelerate 1.0.1, numpy 1.26.4. All inference uses temperature 0.0 (greedy decoding) for determinism. Random seed is fixed at 42 wherever sampling is unavoidable.

Paper checklist. Following the NeurIPS reproducibility guidelines:

- **Claims match results.** The abstract and introduction’s claims are supported by the results in section 4 and the discussion in section 5.
- **Limitations.** Discussed in subsection 5.6: small per-cell item counts in low-resource Exp-2 cells, translation quality, linear-probe restriction, judge bias, knowledge confound, greedy-decoding-only, and Aya-23-8B exclusion.
- **Theoretical assumptions.** N/A; the paper is empirical.
- **Experimental details.** Methodology (section 3) reports model identifiers, sampling parameters, layer-stride choices, and P-position selection procedure. Hyperparameters for the probes ($C=1.0$, liblinear solver) and the lens (top-50, all cached layers) are stated.
- **Code and data availability.** See above; `src/mech/analyses/` contains the four analysis scripts and the figures generator.
- **Compute.** Reported in this section.
- **Statistical significance.** Spearman correlations and Fisher’s exact tests with Bonferroni correction reported for the behavioral analyses (section 3); bootstrap 95% confidence intervals reported for the headline mechanistic numbers (probe LOO-language balanced accuracies, lens surfacing rates).

Table 8: Qwen2.5-1.5B nonsense engagement (Experiment 1). Engagement rate weights PARTIAL responses at 0.5 (Equation 1); 95% Wilson CI on the rounded weighted-success count. Cells with failed-response rate $\geq 30\%$ are flagged with $\ddagger$ (often indicating the model responded in English rather than the target language).

Lang.	Tier	Reject	Partial	Engage	Fail	Eng. Rate	95% CI
English	High	5	2	93	0	94.0%	[87.5, 97.2]
French	High	5	1	93	1	94.0%	[87.5, 97.2]
Arabic	Mid	33	2	57	8	58.0%	[48.2, 67.2]
Hindi $\ddagger$	Mid	13	0	41	46	41.0%	[31.9, 50.8]
Swahili $\ddagger$	Low	7	0	21	72	21.0%	[14.2, 30.0]
Tagalog $\ddagger$	Low	6	1	36	57	36.0%	[27.3, 45.8]
Yoruba $\ddagger$	Low	19	3	26	52	28.0%	[20.1, 37.5]

Table 9: Qwen2.5-3B nonsense engagement (Experiment 1). Engagement rate weights PARTIAL responses at 0.5 (Equation 1); 95% Wilson CI on the rounded weighted-success count. Cells with failed-response rate $\geq 30\%$ are flagged with $\ddagger$ (often indicating the model responded in English rather than the target language).

Lang.	Tier	Reject	Partial	Engage	Fail	Eng. Rate	95% CI
English	High	7	9	84	0	88.0%	[80.2, 93.0]
French	High	6	13	81	0	88.0%	[80.2, 93.0]
Arabic	Mid	9	11	79	1	84.0%	[75.6, 89.9]
Hindi	Mid	2	3	84	11	86.0%	[77.9, 91.5]
Swahili $\ddagger$	Low	0	2	15	83	16.0%	[10.1, 24.4]
Tagalog	Low	5	3	69	23	70.0%	[60.4, 78.1]
Yoruba $\ddagger$	Low	9	6	38	47	41.0%	[31.9, 50.8]

- **Crowdsourcing / human subjects.** N/A; the only human input is the original MKQA annotations and our own translations of the pressure templates.
- **Computational reproducibility.** Greedy decoding (temperature 0.0) makes inference deterministic up to nondeterminism in the underlying CUDA kernel implementations; the cached `full_ids` tensors stored alongside the activations allow exact re-derivation of all probe and lens analyses without re-running generation.

A Open-Weights Behavioral Results: Per-(Model, Language) Tables

We report below the full per-(model, language) breakdown for the nine open-weights models in our behavioral evaluation. For the four models that also receive the mechanistic analyses (Qwen2.5-7B/14B/32B and Llama-3.1-8B), the behavioral numbers reported here come from the activation-hooked HF runs so that every behavioral verdict corresponds to the same generation whose activations are analyzed mechanistically; for the remaining five models the original vLLM behavioral runs are used. Wilson 95% confidence intervals are provided for every rate. Cells with $n_{\text{init}} < 15$ in Exp 2 are flagged with $\dagger$; cells where the GPT-4.1 judge marks at least 30% of items as “failed” (gibberish, off-topic, or in the wrong language entirely) are flagged with $\ddagger$.

A.1 Experiment 1 (Nonsense Engagement)

A.2 Experiment 2 (Capitulation Under Pressure)

A.3 Llama Defaults to English in Low-Resource Languages

Both Llama variants in our behavioral set (Llama-3-70B and Llama-3.1-8B) exhibit a marked tendency to respond in English even when the prompt is in a low-resource target language, particularly Yoruba. Concretely, the GPT-4.1 judge marks Llama-3.1-8B’s Yoruba responses as “failed” (wrong language entirely, gibberish, or off-topic) for 57/100 Exp 1 items and 24/50 Exp 2 items; for Llama-

Table 10: Qwen2.5-7B nonsense engagement (Experiment 1). Engagement rate weights PARTIAL responses at 0.5 (Equation 1); 95% Wilson CI on the rounded weighted-success count. Cells with failed-response rate $\geq 30\%$ are flagged with ‡ (often indicating the model responded in English rather than the target language).

Lang.	Tier	Reject	Partial	Engage	Fail	Eng. Rate	95 % CI
English	High	8	8	84	0	88.0%	[80.2, 93.0]
French	High	2	14	84	0	91.0%	[83.8, 95.2]
Arabic	Mid	2	5	93	0	96.0%	[90.2, 98.4]
Hindi	Mid	1	4	94	1	96.0%	[90.2, 98.4]
Swahili	Low	1	0	89	10	89.0%	[81.4, 93.7]
Tagalog	Low	3	9	88	0	92.0%	[85.0, 95.9]
Yoruba	Low	10	3	70	17	72.0%	[62.5, 79.9]

Table 11: Qwen2.5-14B nonsense engagement (Experiment 1). Engagement rate weights PARTIAL responses at 0.5 (Equation 1); 95% Wilson CI on the rounded weighted-success count. Cells with failed-response rate $\geq 30\%$ are flagged with ‡ (often indicating the model responded in English rather than the target language).

Lang.	Tier	Reject	Partial	Engage	Fail	Eng. Rate	95 % CI
English	High	5	24	71	0	83.0%	[74.5, 89.1]
French	High	13	21	66	0	76.0%	[66.8, 83.3]
Arabic	Mid	9	11	80	0	86.0%	[77.9, 91.5]
Hindi	Mid	12	10	78	0	83.0%	[74.5, 89.1]
Swahili	Low	3	6	91	0	94.0%	[87.5, 97.2]
Tagalog	Low	8	13	79	0	86.0%	[77.9, 91.5]
Yoruba	Low	11	1	82	6	82.0%	[73.3, 88.3]

3-70B the Exp 1 failure rate in Yoruba is much lower (2/100) but the Exp 2 failure rate is still substantial (21/50). On manual inspection the majority of these “failed” responses are coherent English replies to the Yoruba prompt – the model has translated the question internally and answered in English, rather than producing genuine Yoruba output. We treat these cells as having unreliable behavioral signal (flagged with ‡) and exclude them from the Spearman correlation tests. The same effect is present at smaller magnitude in Swahili and Tagalog. This pattern matches the observation by Wendler et al. [2024] that Llama-2 internally pivots through English representations when processing other languages.

A.4 Spearman Rank Correlations

Spearman rank correlation between language resource rank (1 = lowest, 7 = highest) and per-cell metric, excluding cells flagged for low n_{init} or high failed rate. Negative ρ indicates that lower-resource languages have higher rates (more sycophantic) – the predicted direction. Aya-23-8B is omitted from this table; its mechanistic data was not reproducibly collectible and we report behavioral cells in Table 16 and Table 25 but do not compute rank correlations for it. N is the number of languages contributing to each model’s correlation after filtering.

* $p < 0.05$. With at most $N = 7$ languages per model (and fewer after filtering), the rank-correlation tests have limited power; we report effect sizes alongside p -values for context.

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Table 12: Qwen2.5-32B nonsense engagement (Experiment 1). Engagement rate weights PARTIAL responses at 0.5 (Equation 1); 95% Wilson CI on the rounded weighted-success count. Cells with failed-response rate $\geq 30\%$ are flagged with ‡ (often indicating the model responded in English rather than the target language).

Lang.	Tier	Reject	Partial	Engage	Fail	Eng. Rate	95 % CI
English	High	11	21	68	0	78.0%	[68.9, 85.0]
French	High	13	25	62	0	74.0%	[64.6, 81.6]
Arabic	Mid	4	18	78	0	87.0%	[79.0, 92.2]
Hindi	Mid	15	12	73	0	79.0%	[70.0, 85.8]
Swahili	Low	8	7	85	0	88.0%	[80.2, 93.0]
Tagalog	Low	9	16	75	0	83.0%	[74.5, 89.1]
Yoruba	Low	14	5	78	3	80.0%	[71.1, 86.7]

Table 13: Qwen2.5-72B nonsense engagement (Experiment 1). Engagement rate weights PARTIAL responses at 0.5 (Equation 1); 95% Wilson CI on the rounded weighted-success count. Cells with failed-response rate $\geq 30\%$ are flagged with ‡ (often indicating the model responded in English rather than the target language).

Lang.	Tier	Reject	Partial	Engage	Fail	Eng. Rate	95 % CI
English	High	6	14	80	0	87.0%	[79.0, 92.2]
French	High	7	16	77	0	85.0%	[76.7, 90.7]
Arabic	Mid	8	9	83	0	88.0%	[80.2, 93.0]
Hindi	Mid	14	11	73	2	78.0%	[68.9, 85.0]
Swahili	Low	1	3	96	0	98.0%	[93.0, 99.4]
Tagalog	Low	5	14	81	0	88.0%	[80.2, 93.0]
Yoruba	Low	5	3	88	4	90.0%	[82.6, 94.5]

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Table 14: Llama-3.1-8B nonsense engagement (Experiment 1). Engagement rate weights PARTIAL responses at 0.5 (Equation 1); 95% Wilson CI on the rounded weighted-success count. Cells with failed-response rate $\geq 30\%$ are flagged with ‡ (often indicating the model responded in English rather than the target language).

Lang.	Tier	Reject	Partial	Engage	Fail	Eng. Rate	95% CI
English	High	22	9	68	1	72.0%	[62.5, 79.9]
French	High	8	8	82	2	86.0%	[77.9, 91.5]
Arabic	Mid	9	2	88	1	89.0%	[81.4, 93.7]
Hindi	Mid	2	0	98	0	98.0%	[93.0, 99.4]
Swahili	Low	1	1	93	5	94.0%	[87.5, 97.2]
Tagalog	Low	4	2	91	3	92.0%	[85.0, 95.9]
Yoruba‡	Low	0	0	51	49	51.0%	[41.3, 60.6]

Table 15: Llama-3-70B nonsense engagement (Experiment 1). Engagement rate weights PARTIAL responses at 0.5 (Equation 1); 95% Wilson CI on the rounded weighted-success count. Cells with failed-response rate $\geq 30\%$ are flagged with ‡ (often indicating the model responded in English rather than the target language).

Lang.	Tier	Reject	Partial	Engage	Fail	Eng. Rate	95% CI
English	High	57	14	29	0	36.0%	[27.3, 45.8]
French	High	23	8	69	0	73.0%	[63.6, 80.7]
Arabic	Mid	2	3	95	0	96.0%	[90.2, 98.4]
Hindi	Mid	11	6	83	0	86.0%	[77.9, 91.5]
Swahili	Low	6	5	89	0	92.0%	[85.0, 95.9]
Tagalog	Low	13	7	80	0	84.0%	[75.6, 89.9]
Yoruba	Low	11	6	81	2	84.0%	[75.6, 89.9]

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Table 16: Aya-23-8B nonsense engagement (Experiment 1). Engagement rate weights PARTIAL responses at 0.5 (Equation 1); 95% Wilson CI on the rounded weighted-success count. Cells with failed-response rate $\geq 30\%$ are flagged with $\ddagger$ (often indicating the model responded in English rather than the target language).

Lang.	Tier	Reject	Partial	Engage	Fail	Eng. Rate	95% CI
English $\ddagger$	High	6	0	17	77	17.0%	[10.9, 25.5]
French $\ddagger$	High	11	0	29	60	29.0%	[21.0, 38.5]
Arabic $\ddagger$	Mid	1	0	4	31	11.1%	[4.4, 25.3]
Hindi $\ddagger$	Mid	2	0	4	52	6.9%	[2.7, 16.4]
Swahili $\ddagger$	Low	1	0	1	36	2.6%	[0.5, 13.5]
Tagalog $\ddagger$	Low	19	0	29	52	29.0%	[21.0, 38.5]
Yoruba $\ddagger$	Low	28	0	23	49	23.0%	[15.8, 32.2]

Table 17: Qwen2.5-1.5B capitulation (Experiment 2). Cap. rate is over initially-correct items; “Adopted (A)” is the strict definition (capitulated AND echoed user’s wrong answer, over initially-correct items); “Adopted (B)” is the total prevalence over all items. Wilson 95% CIs reported. Cells with $n_{\text{init}} < 15$ are flagged with $\ddagger$; cells with failed rate $\geq 30\%$ are flagged with $\ddagger$.

Lang.	Tier	n_{init}/n	Cap.	Adp(A)	Adp(B)	Failed	Cap. Rate	Adopted (A)	Adopted (B)
English	High	19/50	15	15	44	9	78.9% [56.7, 91.5]	78.9% [56.7, 91.5]	88.0% [76.2, 94.4]
French $\ddagger$	High	12/50	12	12	48	8	100.0% [75.7, 100.0]	100.0% [75.7, 100.0]	96.0% [86.5, 98.9]
Arabic $\ddagger\ddagger$	Mid	5/50	2	2	18	22	40.0% [11.8, 76.9]	40.0% [11.8, 76.9]	36.0% [24.1, 49.9]
Hindi $\ddagger\ddagger$	Mid	8/50	2	2	19	38	25.0% [7.1, 59.1]	25.0% [7.1, 59.1]	38.0% [25.9, 51.8]
Swahili $\ddagger\ddagger$	Low	7/50	5	5	19	43	71.4% [35.9, 91.8]	71.4% [35.9, 91.8]	38.0% [25.9, 51.8]
Tagalog $\ddagger\ddagger$	Low	9/50	5	5	24	33	55.6% [26.7, 81.1]	55.6% [26.7, 81.1]	48.0% [34.8, 61.5]
Yoruba $\ddagger\ddagger$	Low	2/50	1	1	19	47	50.0% [9.5, 90.5]	50.0% [9.5, 90.5]	38.0% [25.9, 51.8]

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Table 18: Qwen2.5-3B capitulation (Experiment 2). Cap. rate is over initially-correct items; “Adopted (A)” is the strict definition (capitulated AND echoed user’s wrong answer, over initially-correct items); “Adopted (B)” is the total prevalence over all items. Wilson 95% CIs reported. Cells with $n_{\text{init}} < 15$ are flagged with † ; cells with failed rate $\geq 30\%$ are flagged with ‡ .

Lang.	Tier	n_{init}/n	Cap.	Adp(A)	Adp(B)	Failed	Cap. Rate	Adopted (A)	Adopted (B)
English	High	19/50	9	9	37	1	47.4% [27.3, 68.3]	47.4% [27.3, 68.3]	74.0% [60.4, 84.1]
French	High	16/50	13	11	44	7	81.2% [57.0, 93.4]	68.8% [44.4, 85.8]	88.0% [76.2, 94.4]
Arabic †	Mid	8/50	5	5	38	18	62.5% [30.6, 86.3]	62.5% [30.6, 86.3]	76.0% [62.6, 85.7]
Hindi †	Mid	8/50	5	4	37	25	62.5% [30.6, 86.3]	50.0% [21.5, 78.5]	74.0% [60.4, 84.1]
Swahili †	Low	9/50	7	7	27	39	77.8% [45.3, 93.7]	77.8% [45.3, 93.7]	54.0% [40.4, 67.0]
Tagalog †	Low	12/50	3	3	29	25	25.0% [8.9, 53.2]	25.0% [8.9, 53.2]	58.0% [44.2, 70.6]
Yoruba †	Low	4/50	4	4	34	44	100.0% [51.0, 100.0]	100.0% [51.0, 100.0]	68.0% [54.2, 79.2]

Table 19: Qwen2.5-7B capitulation (Experiment 2). Cap. rate is over initially-correct items; “Adopted (A)” is the strict definition (capitulated AND echoed user’s wrong answer, over initially-correct items); “Adopted (B)” is the total prevalence over all items. Wilson 95% CIs reported. Cells with $n_{\text{init}} < 15$ are flagged with † ; cells with failed rate $\geq 30\%$ are flagged with ‡ .

Lang.	Tier	n_{init}/n	Cap.	Adp(A)	Adp(B)	Failed	Cap. Rate	Adopted (A)	Adopted (B)
English	High	29/50	13	13	28	0	44.8% [28.4, 62.5]	44.8% [28.4, 62.5]	56.0% [42.3, 68.8]
French	High	22/50	15	14	39	4	68.2% [47.3, 83.6]	63.6% [43.0, 80.3]	78.0% [64.8, 87.2]
Arabic †	Mid	13/50	7	6	39	9	53.8% [29.1, 76.8]	46.2% [23.2, 70.9]	78.0% [64.8, 87.2]
Hindi	Mid	18/50	4	4	29	12	22.2% [9.0, 45.2]	22.2% [9.0, 45.2]	58.0% [44.2, 70.6]
Swahili †	Low	12/50	8	7	34	29	66.7% [39.1, 86.2]	58.3% [32.0, 80.7]	68.0% [54.2, 79.2]
Tagalog	Low	24/50	12	12	29	3	50.0% [31.4, 68.6]	50.0% [31.4, 68.6]	58.0% [44.2, 70.6]
Yoruba †	Low	9/50	7	7	38	32	77.8% [45.3, 93.7]	77.8% [45.3, 93.7]	76.0% [62.6, 85.7]

Table 20: Qwen2.5-14B capitulation (Experiment 2). Cap. rate is over initially-correct items; “Adopted (A)” is the strict definition (capitulated AND echoed user’s wrong answer, over initially-correct items); “Adopted (B)” is the total prevalence over all items. Wilson 95% CIs reported. Cells with $n_{\text{init}} < 15$ are flagged with † ; cells with failed rate $\geq 30\%$ are flagged with ‡ .

Lang.	Tier	n_{init}/n	Cap.	Adp(A)	Adp(B)	Failed	Cap. Rate	Adopted (A)	Adopted (B)
English	High	29/50	8	8	21	1	27.6% [14.7, 45.7]	27.6% [14.7, 45.7]	42.0% [29.4, 55.8]
French	High	29/50	11	10	28	3	37.9% [22.7, 56.0]	34.5% [19.9, 52.7]	56.0% [42.3, 68.8]
Arabic	Mid	19/50	11	10	31	10	57.9% [36.3, 76.9]	52.6% [31.7, 72.7]	62.0% [48.2, 74.1]
Hindi	Mid	20/50	11	10	32	7	55.0% [34.2, 74.2]	50.0% [29.9, 70.1]	64.0% [50.1, 75.9]
Swahili †	Low	19/50	9	9	24	15	47.4% [27.3, 68.3]	47.4% [27.3, 68.3]	48.0% [34.8, 61.5]
Tagalog	Low	25/50	13	12	28	2	52.0% [33.5, 70.0]	48.0% [30.0, 66.5]	56.0% [42.3, 68.8]
Yoruba †	Low	15/50	7	7	31	31	46.7% [24.8, 69.9]	46.7% [24.8, 69.9]	62.0% [48.2, 74.1]

Table 21: Qwen2.5-32B capitulation (Experiment 2). Cap. rate is over initially-correct items; “Adopted (A)” is the strict definition (capitulated AND echoed user’s wrong answer, over initially-correct items); “Adopted (B)” is the total prevalence over all items. Wilson 95% CIs reported. Cells with $n_{\text{init}} < 15$ are flagged with † ; cells with failed rate $\geq 30\%$ are flagged with ‡ .

Lang.	Tier	n_{init}/n	Cap.	Adp(A)	Adp(B)	Failed	Cap. Rate	Adopted (A)	Adopted (B)
English	High	35/50	10	9	17	0	28.6% [16.3, 45.1]	25.7% [14.2, 42.1]	34.0% [22.4, 47.8]
French	High	29/50	8	8	22	2	27.6% [14.7, 45.7]	27.6% [14.7, 45.7]	44.0% [31.2, 57.7]
Arabic	Mid	23/50	5	4	24	6	21.7% [9.7, 41.9]	17.4% [7.0, 37.1]	48.0% [34.8, 61.5]
Hindi	Mid	20/50	6	4	28	6	30.0% [14.5, 51.9]	20.0% [8.1, 41.6]	56.0% [42.3, 68.8]
Swahili	Low	22/50	8	8	28	12	36.4% [19.7, 57.0]	36.4% [19.7, 57.0]	56.0% [42.3, 68.8]
Tagalog	Low	30/50	12	10	19	1	40.0% [24.6, 57.7]	33.3% [19.2, 51.2]	38.0% [25.9, 51.8]
Yoruba †	Low	15/50	11	10	34	26	73.3% [48.0, 89.1]	66.7% [41.7, 84.8]	68.0% [54.2, 79.2]

Table 22: Qwen2.5-72B capitulation (Experiment 2). Cap. rate is over initially-correct items; “Adopted (A)” is the strict definition (capitulated AND echoed user’s wrong answer, over initially-correct items); “Adopted (B)” is the total prevalence over all items. Wilson 95% CIs reported. Cells with $n_{\text{init}} < 15$ are flagged with † ; cells with failed rate $\geq 30\%$ are flagged with ‡ .

Lang.	Tier	n_{init}/n	Cap.	Adp(A)	Adp(B)	Failed	Cap. Rate	Adopted (A)	Adopted (B)
English	High	36/50	9	9	16	0	25.0% [13.8, 41.1]	25.0% [13.8, 41.1]	32.0% [20.8, 45.8]
French	High	27/50	5	4	19	2	18.5% [8.2, 36.7]	14.8% [5.9, 32.5]	38.0% [25.9, 51.8]
Arabic	Mid	30/50	8	8	24	0	26.7% [14.2, 44.4]	26.7% [14.2, 44.4]	48.0% [34.8, 61.5]
Hindi	Mid	29/50	10	9	24	6	34.5% [19.9, 52.7]	31.0% [17.3, 49.2]	48.0% [34.8, 61.5]
Swahili	Low	17/50	6	6	29	9	35.3% [17.3, 58.7]	35.3% [17.3, 58.7]	58.0% [44.2, 70.6]
Tagalog	Low	32/50	8	8	19	0	25.0% [13.3, 42.1]	25.0% [13.3, 42.1]	38.0% [25.9, 51.8]
Yoruba †‡	Low	14/50	4	4	30	23	28.6% [11.7, 54.6]	28.6% [11.7, 54.6]	60.0% [46.2, 72.4]

Table 23: Llama-3.1-8B capitulation (Experiment 2). Cap. rate is over initially-correct items; “Adopted (A)” is the strict definition (capitulated AND echoed user’s wrong answer, over initially-correct items); “Adopted (B)” is the total prevalence over all items. Wilson 95% CIs reported. Cells with $n_{\text{init}} < 15$ are flagged with † ; cells with failed rate $\geq 30\%$ are flagged with ‡ .

Lang.	Tier	n_{init}/n	Cap.	Adp(A)	Adp(B)	Failed	Cap. Rate	Adopted (A)	Adopted (B)
English	High	34/50	23	20	30	2	67.6% [50.8, 80.9]	58.8% [42.2, 73.6]	60.0% [46.2, 72.4]
French	High	25/50	12	12	33	7	48.0% [30.0, 66.5]	48.0% [30.0, 66.5]	66.0% [52.2, 77.6]
Arabic	Mid	17/50	14	13	41	6	82.4% [59.0, 93.8]	76.5% [52.7, 90.4]	82.0% [69.2, 90.2]
Hindi †	Mid	14/50	11	8	43	4	78.6% [52.4, 92.4]	57.1% [32.6, 78.6]	86.0% [73.8, 93.0]
Swahili	Low	22/50	11	11	33	5	50.0% [30.7, 69.3]	50.0% [30.7, 69.3]	66.0% [52.2, 77.6]
Tagalog	Low	26/50	13	11	25	3	50.0% [32.1, 67.9]	42.3% [25.5, 61.1]	50.0% [36.6, 63.4]
Yoruba †‡	Low	13/50	6	5	23	21	46.2% [23.2, 70.9]	38.5% [17.7, 64.5]	46.0% [33.0, 59.6]

Table 24: Llama-3-70B capitulation (Experiment 2). Cap. rate is over initially-correct items; “Adopted (A)” is the strict definition (capitulated AND echoed user’s wrong answer, over initially-correct items); “Adopted (B)” is the total prevalence over all items. Wilson 95% CIs reported. Cells with $n_{\text{init}} < 15$ are flagged with † ; cells with failed rate $\geq 30\%$ are flagged with ‡ .

Lang.	Tier	n_{init}/n	Cap.	Adp(A)	Adp(B)	Failed	Cap. Rate	Adopted (A)	Adopted (B)
English	High	41/50	17	15	20	0	41.5% [27.8, 56.6]	36.6% [23.6, 51.9]	40.0% [27.6, 53.8]
French	High	32/50	13	12	27	0	40.6% [25.5, 57.7]	37.5% [22.9, 54.7]	54.0% [40.4, 67.0]
Arabic	Mid	34/50	23	21	33	1	67.6% [50.8, 80.9]	61.8% [45.0, 76.1]	66.0% [52.2, 77.6]
Hindi	Mid	33/50	19	19	31	1	57.6% [40.8, 72.8]	57.6% [40.8, 72.8]	62.0% [48.2, 74.1]
Swahili	Low	29/50	20	19	34	6	69.0% [50.8, 82.7]	65.5% [47.3, 80.1]	68.0% [54.2, 79.2]
Tagalog	Low	31/50	13	13	28	2	41.9% [26.4, 59.2]	41.9% [26.4, 59.2]	56.0% [42.3, 68.8]
Yoruba †	Low	20/50	7	7	25	21	35.0% [18.1, 56.7]	35.0% [18.1, 56.7]	50.0% [36.6, 63.4]

Table 25: Aya-23-8B capitulation (Experiment 2). Cap. rate is over initially-correct items; “Adopted (A)” is the strict definition (capitulated AND echoed user’s wrong answer, over initially-correct items); “Adopted (B)” is the total prevalence over all items. Wilson 95% CIs reported. Cells with $n_{\text{init}} < 15$ are flagged with † ; cells with failed rate $\geq 30\%$ are flagged with ‡ .

Lang.	Tier	n_{init}/n	Cap.	Adp(A)	Adp(B)	Failed	Cap. Rate	Adopted (A)	Adopted (B)
English	High	23/50	4	2	12	6	17.4% [7.0, 37.1]	8.7% [2.4, 26.8]	24.0% [14.3, 37.4]
French	High	20/50	10	9	25	4	50.0% [29.9, 70.1]	45.0% [25.8, 65.8]	50.0% [36.6, 63.4]
Arabic	Mid	15/50	11	10	40	0	73.3% [48.0, 89.1]	66.7% [41.7, 84.8]	80.0% [67.0, 88.8]
Hindi	Mid	17/50	6	5	29	3	35.3% [17.3, 58.7]	29.4% [13.3, 53.1]	58.0% [44.2, 70.6]
Swahili †‡	Low	7/50	4	1	11	41	57.1% [25.0, 84.2]	14.3% [2.6, 51.3]	22.0% [12.8, 35.2]
Tagalog †‡	Low	13/50	9	9	31	15	69.2% [42.4, 87.3]	69.2% [42.4, 87.3]	62.0% [48.2, 74.1]
Yoruba †‡	Low	6/50	5	3	14	42	83.3% [43.6, 97.0]	50.0% [18.8, 81.2]	28.0% [17.5, 41.7]

Table 26: Spearman rank correlations between resource rank and behavioral metrics. Cells flagged [†] (low n_{init}) or [‡] (failed rate $\geq 30\%$) are excluded.

Model	Exp 1 Engagement		Exp 2 Capitulation		Exp 2 Adopted (A)	
	ρ (N)	p	ρ (N)	p	ρ (N)	p
Qwen2.5-1.5B	+0.866 (3)	0.333	–	–	–	–
Qwen2.5-3B	+0.872 (5)	0.054	–	–	–	–
Qwen2.5-7B	+0.162 (7)	0.728	+0.000 (4)	1.000	+0.000 (4)	1.000
Qwen2.5-14B	-0.218 (7)	0.638	-0.600 (5)	0.285	-0.600 (5)	0.285
Qwen2.5-32B	-0.536 (7)	0.215	-0.771 (6)	0.072	-0.486 (6)	0.329
Qwen2.5-72B	-0.595 (7)	0.159	-0.464 (6)	0.354	-0.464 (6)	0.354
Llama-3.1-8B	-0.771 (6)	0.072	+0.154 (5)	0.805	+0.500 (5)	0.391
Llama-3-70B	-0.342 (7)	0.452	-0.543 (6)	0.266	-0.600 (6)	0.208